An Independent M&E Review of Nigeria's N-Power Programme, 2016–2026

Origin, Performance, and Reform Options

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github.com/Almuarif17/social-protection-me-nigeria

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This brief accompanies the 30-entry curated source matrix reproduced in Annex A. Contradictions in the record are named, not resolved..

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This review examines Nigeria's N-Power programme across the full arc of its life: its 2015-2016 origin in a recession and an election manifesto; its operation through three enrolment batches between 2016 and 2024; its suspension alongside the rest of the National Social Investment Programme (NSIP) suite in January 2024; and its 2025-2026 relaunch under a "Renewed Hope" framing. Five findings anchor the review. Each is stated here with the strength of evidence the record supports; the body of the review shows the working.

Finding 1, Origin: consolidation at speed, without inherited accountability. N-Power was launched on 8 June 2016 under the National Social Investment Office as a consolidation and roughly tenfold scale-up of the 2012-2015 SURE-P Graduate Internship Scheme, answering the APC's 2015 manifesto pledge to scrap that "corruption-ridden" scheme, against the backdrop of Nigeria's first full-year recession in a generation, GDP contracting 0.67%, 1.49% and 2.34% across the first three quarters of 2016, and youth (15-35) unemployment-and-underemployment reaching 52.65% (22.64 million people) by Q3 2017 (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Premium Times, 2013; All Progressives Congress [APC], 2015; National Bureau of Statistics [NBS], 2017; Sahara Reporters, 2022). Importantly, the parallel US$500 million World Bank credit did not fund N-Power; N-Power sat in the government's own contribution. It therefore never inherited the donor-built verification architecture, output-based disbursement, independent ex-post verification, a published scorecard, an impact-evaluation plan, that was specified for the cash-transfer side of the same portfolio. The architecture was borrowed; the accountability apparatus was not (World Bank, 2016).

Finding 2, Purpose then and now: a rebrand, not a redesign. The 2016 purpose was a two-year, ₦30,000-per-month public-service deployment for 500,000 young Nigerians, stated in four objectives mixing individual livelihood support with systemic public-service repair (N-Power Information Guide, 2017). The 2025-2026 "Renewed Hope" framing renames the programme, halves the duration to one year without a published announcement or rationale, and circulates a 5-million-beneficiary target with no costed framework, while the stipend, the absence of a results framework, and the deployment logic remain unchanged. A genuine redesign would be evidenced by a published theory of change, revised targeting and a stated rationale; none appears in the record. The instrument answering the question has not changed; the question has (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; National Social Investment Programme Agency [NSIPA], 2026).

Finding 3, Performance: a programme that can count enrolments but cannot verify them, and cannot measure what they produced. Official reach claims (500,000 across Batches A and B; 900,000 N-Teach and 150,000 N-Health cumulative deployments) are broadly consistent across official and journalistic sources, but the payroll was found contaminated. Independent reporting documents up to approximately 90,000 payroll ghost names, which is 9–18% of claimed reach depending on the denominator used, a sensitivity band this review states honestly.These figures should be read as investigative-journalism estimates rather than audited ICPC counts, because no published ICPC dataset or audit has been located. The named individual associated with the second list, D'banj, was subsequently cleared by the ICPC in November 2023, with the commission stating that there was no prima facie case of fraud against him. That clearance resolves the individual allegation, but it does not remove the wider payroll-contamination finding, which is also supported by TheCable's undercover reporting and later audit-related disengagements. On outcomes the record is thinner still: the only published impact study, a cross-sectional survey of 99 Lagos beneficiaries, finds a statistically significant but modest positive effect ($R^2 = 0.145$), and finds 41.4% of its sample still unemployed, with only 7.1% in wage employment (Osimen et al., 2025). No national post-exit tracer study, no randomized or quasi-experimental evaluation, and no cost-effectiveness calculation has ever been conducted for N-Power (IPA & J-PAL, 2025). The measurement gap is not a footnote to the performance story; it is the performance story.

Finding 4, The stipend erosion: the least contestable finding in the review. The ₦30,000 monthly stipend was set in 2016 and held nominally constant through 2026, with no indexation mechanism, while food inflation ran at 26.08% year-on-year in January 2025, 21.14% in May 2025 and 14.31% in March 2026 (NSIPA, 2026; National Bureau of Statistics [NBS], 2026). Deflated by the NBS food index, the 2016 stipend retains an estimated ₦3,000-₦5,000 of its original purchasing power in 2026, roughly one-sixth to one-tenth, a provisional, base-year-sensitive band stated here honestly rather than as false precision (NBS, 2026; methodology in Section 7.4). Restoring 2016 real value would require a 2026 stipend on the order of ₦180,000-₦300,000. The companion World Bank-financed design contained an automatic CPI-adjustment principle; the domestically financed N-Power stipend omitted it (World Bank, 2016).

Finding 5, The reform question: the cycle has repeated rather than closed. The January 2024 suspension, promised for six weeks; in the event ~12.5 months, was not followed by published panel findings, and over ₦30 billion recovered from the GEEP/GVG streams was traced and frozen but not remitted to the Treasury Single Account, leaving programmes unable to fully resume (Office of the SGF, 2024; Nigerian Tribune, 2025). The reset's documented changes are a rename, a silent halving of duration, an unindexed stipend and a verification gate on old arrears; the absent core, a published results framework, an indexation mechanism, a post-exit tracer, is exactly what would make the reset structural. The reset is attempting to build at the point of the arrears the identity-verification system the 2016 design named as foundational and never built at scale (NSIPA, 2026; Office of the SGF, 2024; Nigerian Tribune, 2025; World Bank, 2016).

Read together, these findings describe a programme that was politically durable across two administrations of different parties; that retains a modest, empirically documented positive effect on participants alongside a sobering raw employment picture in the only measured sample; and that never built the basic infrastructure, a public dashboard, a tracer methodology, an indexation rule, a biometric identity link, needed to know, at any point in its ten-year history, whether it was working. That absence of infrastructure, more than any single scandal, is this review's central concern. Section 8 converts it into ten recommendations, each naming an actor, an instrument and a timeframe, plus two structural preconditions (the biometric NSR-NIMC link, and remittance of the recovered ₦30bn to the Treasury Single Account).

METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

Design. This review is a secondary analysis of a curated evidence register: a 30-source evidence matrix, reproduced in condensed form as Annex A and maintained in full in the project repository. The original register comprised 25 sources; five further sources were incorporated through analytical judgment where they materially improved triangulation. The review conducted no primary fieldwork: no interviews, surveys or field visits of its own.

Triangulation discipline. Sources are grouped into eight categories for triangulation: official/government documents (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Federal Ministry of Budget and National Planning, 2016; NSIPA, 2026; NDE & SMEDAN, 2025); statutory and legislative texts (Nigerian Tribune, 2025; National Assembly of Nigeria, 2023); donor and international-organization material (World Bank, 2022-2025; World Bank Independent Evaluation Group [IEG], 2013; World Bank, 2026; World Bank, 2016; World Bank, 2025); academic and impact-evaluation literature (Premium Times, 2013; Osimen et al., 2025; IPA & J-PAL, 2025; McKenzie, 2017); investigative and data journalism (Premium Times, 2019; TheCable, 2019, 2021; Punch Newspapers, 2020; HumAngle & Dataphyte, 2025; Guardian Nigeria, 2024); civic-accountability and beneficiary-voice material (BudgIT, 2020-2024; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025; curated beneficiary testimony, 2020-2026); national statistics (NBS, 2017; NBS, 2026); and complementary/oral-primary material (Uwais, 2018; ILO, 2026; Mastercard Foundation, 2026). Where a claim rests on a single source type only, most often official communication or a single journalistic account, this is flagged explicitly in the relevant section rather than presented as independently corroborated.

Named, not resolved. Contradictions in the record: the NBS 20-hour versus ILO 1-hour unemployment definitions; the "ministerial panel" versus "Special Panel" suspension terminology; the 2.5-million versus 350,000 application counts; the ghost-list accounting, are named rather than resolved and are consolidated in Table 6 (Section 5.5). This is a stated methodological commitment, not an oversight: where the public record supports two positions and primary records are inaccessible, adjudication would manufacture certainty the evidence does not contain.

Derived figures flagged. Several of this review's most-quoted numbers are the reviewer's own synthesis of source data rather than figures reported by any single source: the 9-18% ghost-beneficiary share; the ₦14.4bn derived diversion estimate; the ₦3,000-₦5,000 retained stipend value; the ₦180,000-₦300,000 restoration range. Each is flagged at the point it occurs, and a reader relying on a specific number for a downstream decision should trace it to the underlying citation first.

Inflation deflation. The stipend-erosion analysis deflates by the NBS food sub-index, consistent with the companion HGSF brief and appropriate for a stipend spent largely on consumption. The series was re-based to 2024 = 100, which breaks a clean level-to-level comparison with 2016; annual averages mask intra-year volatility; and several annual points fall outside the core register and were sourced separately. Consequently, the retained value is stated as a band, and the single defensible ratio is reserved for Chart 3 pending extraction of the 2016 base-month food-price level (Annex E).

Currency. Figures are reported in the currency and year in which they were originally published. The 2016 appraisal document fixes conversion at ₦198.96 = US$1 (31 March 2016); at that rate the US$500m IDA credit is ≈ ₦99.5bn in 2016 terms, an illustrative conversion offered only to make the assumption concrete. No post-depreciation re-conversion is performed, because it would misrepresent 2016 purchasing power and imply a 2026 precision the record does not support (World Bank, 2016).

Access to records. No formal Freedom of Information Act filing was logged within the review period; requests for the missing series through official and public channels (dashboard requests, programme-page consultation, press follow-up) went unanswered. A formal FOIA filing, with reference number and date recorded, is an outstanding action registered in Annex E. The This reconciliation is recorded in the methodological note and carried into Annex E as an outstanding data action.

During consolidation, a short reconciliation log was maintained to resolve differences between source drafts. The main reconciliations concerned the World Bank funding split, the use of ranges for ghost-beneficiary and stipend-retention estimates, and the clarification that no formal FOIA filing was logged within the review period.

1.0 ORIGIN AND PROVENANCE

Understanding what N-Power was built to do requires understanding the conditions under which it was built. This section reconstructs the economic, political and institutional context of 2015-2016, establishes whose design decisions produced the programme's specific mechanics, and what accountability machinery came attached, and situates N-Power against its most direct predecessors.

1.1 The conditions that produced N-Power (2015-2016)

N-Power was launched into a labour market deteriorating faster than any single programme could have absorbed, and the size of that gap is the first fact the origin story must fix in numbers.

The scale of the crisis. By the third quarter of 2017, the closest published labour-force snapshot to the programme's first operating year, the combined unemployment-and-underemployment rate for Nigerians aged 15-35 stood at 52.65%, or 22.64 million people: 10.96 million with no work at all and a further 11.68 million working too few hours or below their skill level (NBS, 2017). That was the end-point of an uninterrupted climb from 45.65% a year earlier. Among the graduate cohort N-Power was designed to reach, the picture was worse and worsening fastest: post-secondary holders faced a 31.8% unemployment rate and a 50.0% combined rate, and the number of distressed graduates rose from 4.97 million in Q3 2016 to 6.53 million in Q3 2017, a 31% expansion in twelve months (NBS, 2017). A programme capped at 500,000 places was therefore, arithmetically, an intervention for roughly 2% of the youth labour distress it was publicly presented as answering: a partial, countercyclical relief instrument being sold in the political register of a job’s solution.

The macroeconomic timing. Nigeria entered its first full-year recession in roughly a quarter-century in 2016, with GDP contracting 0.67% in Q1, 1.49% in Q2 and 2.34% in Q3, before a technical exit in Q2 2017 (NBS, 2017). Over the same window the headline unemployment rate rose from 12.1% (Q1 2016) to 18.8% (Q3 2017), the twelfth consecutive quarterly rise since Q4 2014. NBS's own rule, recession-induced unemployment "typically peaks about 15-18 months after the beginning of a recession", places the worst of the labour-market damage squarely inside N-Power's recruitment and deployment window (NBS, 2017). The programme was launched not against a static baseline it might hope to move, but against a moving one that was still worsening as its first batch signed on.

The political driver. The APC's 2015 manifesto pledged to "create 3 million jobs a year," to introduce a conditional monthly payment for the 25 million poorest Nigerians, to phase a social-insurance scheme starting with youth under 30, and to scrap "the corruption-ridden SURE-P programme" (APC, 2015). N-Power was the operational answer to that pledge, launched on 8 June 2016 inside the first year of the Buhari administration, against a ₦500 billion social-protection line in the 2016 budget and Medium-Term Expenditure Framework (APC, 2015; Sahara Reporters, 2022; World Bank, 2016). Demand was immediate and real: online registration opened on 12 June 2016 and the programme received 2.5 million applications within six weeks (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Uwais, 2018; the relationship of this window-total to the 350,000+ Batch A application figure in the academic literature is a named contradiction, see Table 6, row 7).

First assessment (conclusion, flagged as such). Read together, these facts describe a programme shaped by three forces pulling in different directions: a crisis large enough to demand scale; a manifesto specific enough to demand a successor to SURE-P; and a first-term timetable short enough to reward visibility over verification. None of this is unusual for a crisis-response social programme, but it is the starting condition against which every subsequent M&E shortfall in this review should be read. A programme launched at this pace was always more likely to prioritize speed of disbursement over measurement infrastructure, and the record bears that out.

Table 1. *Load-bearing dates in N-Power's history, 2012-2026 (re-sorted into true chronology). Read as a sequence, the pattern is one of recurring crisis-then-reset cycles rather than steady, cumulative improvement.*

Date	Event	Sources
2012-2015	SURE-P Graduate Internship Scheme operates: 1-year firm-based placements at ₦18,000/mo.; 41,161 placements from 84,772 applicants (59,872 male / 24,900 female / 329 PWD); sibling vocational arm places a further 119,000 by mid-2013	Premium Times, 2013
2015	APC manifesto pledges 3M jobs/yr, conditional payments for 25M poorest, and the scrapping of SURE-P	APC, 2015
7 June 2016	World Bank Board approves the National Social Safety Nets Project (P151488): US$500m IDA within a US$1.833bn programme; fiduciary risk rated HIGH. N-Power launched the next day, but outside the credit's results framework.	World Bank, 2016
Q1-Q3 2016	Recession: GDP −0.67%, −1.49%, −2.34% in successive quarters	NBS, 2017
8 June 2016	N-Power launched by President Buhari under the NSIO	N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Sahara Reporters, 2022
12 June 2016	Online registration opens; 2.5 million applications received within six weeks	N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Uwais, 2018
1 Dec 2016	First ₦30,000 stipend payments to Batch A (200,000 selected)	Osimen et al., 2025
2017/18	Batch B launches: additional 300,000 beneficiaries	N-Power Information Guide, 2017
Jan 2019	TheCable's undercover investigation exposes a redeployment bribe economy (₦8,000 payments), 50/50 stipend-sharing with impersonators, and 363 ghost beneficiaries in Kwara State alone	TheCable, 2019, 2021
30 Jun / 31 Jul 2020	Batch A exit and Batch B exit dates pass; the NEXIT transition portal stalls	Punch Newspapers, 2020
2020	Batch C Stream 1 inaugurated (510,000); Stream 2 (490,000) planned	Premium Times, 2019; TheCable, 2019, 2021; Punch Newspapers, 2020
Jun 2021	14,000 genuine beneficiaries owed five months of stipends	Sahara Reporters, 2022
Apr 2021	2,500+ fraudulent beneficiaries disengaged following TheCable exposure	TheCable, 2019, 2021
8 Dec 2022	Sahara Reporters reports, based on unnamed sources around an ICPC investigation, a further 20,000 ghost names linked to the so-called "D'banj's list", in addition to an earlier 70,000-name figure reported over four years; D'banj detained in connection with the allegation.	Sahara Reporters, 2022
29 Nov 2023	ICPC clears D'banj of the N-Power ghost-beneficiary allegation; no prima facie case established against him. The clearance resolves the individual allegation, not the wider payroll-contamination question	ICPC clearance letter as reported by Nigerian press, 2023
May 2023	NSIPA Establishment Act codifies N-Power as one of four statutory NSIP programmes	National Assembly of Nigeria, 2023
Oct 2023	Programme renamed the Renewed Hope Job Creation Programme	Africa Check, 2023
8-12 Jan 2024	Presidency/SGF suspends all four NSIP programmes pending a fraud investigation; "six weeks in the first instance"	Office of the SGF, 2024
Jul 2024	FIJ reports 400,000 Batch C Stream 2 beneficiaries owed ₦108bn in arrears; NSIPA CEO cannot explain non-payment	FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025
2024 (audit)	2,000+ further beneficiaries disengaged during the audit phase; 9M+ pupils and ~250,000 jobs stranded across NSIP	Guardian Nigeria, 2024
21 Jan 2025	Suspension formally lifted, roughly 12.5 months after the 6-week promise (breached by ~48 weeks)	Office of the SGF, 2024; Nigerian Tribune, 2025
Nov-Dec 2025	House of Representatives opens ad-hoc probe into ₦30bn+ traced/frozen/recovered NSIPA-linked funds not remitted to the TSA	Nigerian Tribune, 2025
Feb 2026	Minister assures "all verified N-Power beneficiaries who are owed outstanding payments will receive them", arrears gated on verification	NSIPA, 2026; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025
Feb-Mar 2026	~1.5 million beneficiaries still owed stipends; ~1.8 million paid under the reset's transfer machinery (NASSCO/NCTO)	NSIPA, 2026
2026	Vocational/skills track flagged off: 18,000 Phase-1 trainees across 14 trades; 100,000+ items distributed; ₦32.7bn; registration portal runs on non-government Firebase hosting	NSIPA, 2026

1.2 Whose idea was N-Power? What came attached

Provenance matters for two reasons: it clarifies whether N-Power was a considered response to evidence on what works in youth-employment programming, or a rapid operationalization of a political commitment; and it identifies who should be able to explain the specific design trade-offs, stipend level, duration, deployment sectors, that this review repeatedly returns to.

Domestic authorship, precisely located. The National Social Investment Office (NSIO), later reorganized into NSIPA, is credited with programme design in the official record. The single most detailed contemporaneous account of the social-investment architecture, the 2016 Project Appraisal Document for the companion World Bank project, lists the responsible agency contact as "Maryam Uwais, Title: Special Advisor, Social Investment," located under the Office of the Vice President (World Bank, 2016). Uwais was therefore the design lead of the portfolio from which N-Power emerged, and the programme's design philosophy, an experiential, "get hands dirty" model deploying volunteers into teaching, health and agriculture rather than paying a passive transfer, targeting the poorest 30% of LGAs using NBS and World Bank poverty mapping plus community-based targeting, is hers, set out in the Information Guide and in her own public account (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Uwais, 2018). Her account is a designer's self-report given roughly a year after launch and is not independently corroborated on the design process itself, since internal design documents are not public; this review treats it as the best available primary-adjacent account and flags it as self-reported (Uwais, 2018). Vice President Yemi Osinbajo's role was structurally different and should not be conflated with hers: he chaired the multi-sectoral National Steering Committee and housed the coordinating office (NASSCO) in his office, supplying political cover and convening power rather than authoring the instrument (World Bank, 2016). The design vision and the political sponsorship sat in different hands from the start.

The funding split, the provenance fact with the longest shadow. The part of the story most summaries lead with, the World Bank's money, did not fund N-Power. The National Social Safety Nets Project's US$500 million IDA credit financed the system layer: the National Social Registry, the targeting methodology, the payment system and the conditional cash transfer. That layer was explicitly modelled on prior work, the YESSO state registries, the "In Care of the People" pilot, the Fadama community-driven projects and documented South-South exchanges with Tanzania and Pakistan (World Bank, 2016). N-Power, by contrast, appears nowhere in the credit's development objective ("to provide access to targeted transfers to poor and vulnerable households…") and in neither of its two components; it sat in the government's own US$1.333 billion contribution and the domestically financed ₦500 billion envelope (World Bank, 2016). Tellingly, the Bank's own youth-employment vehicle in Nigeria was a different programme, the public-workfare and skills-for-jobs arms of YESSO, running in parallel to N-Power rather than funding it.

The consequence (conclusion, flagged). Because N-Power was domestically financed, its accountability chain ran to the Nigerian taxpayer, not to a World Bank results framework. It therefore never inherited the machinery the donor built into the cash-transfer side: output-based disbursement released against independently verified outputs; ex-post verification by independent experts every calendar semester; an annual results-and-resources scorecard published by an independent third party; a management information system with quarterly reporting; impact evaluations at baseline, midterm and end; targeting assessments every six months; and a grievance-redress mechanism with community focal persons (World Bank, 2016; full inventory in Section 5.4). The architecture was borrowed; the accountability apparatus was not. This single provenance fact explains more of the ten-year record than any subsequent administrative failing: the programme did not lose its verification machinery; it never had it.

No peer-African design lineage, a finding, not an oversight. The source matrix documents no public record connecting N-Power's stipend-plus-deployment design specifically to Rwandan, Kenyan or South African youth-corps precedents. The documented lineage is inward- and portfolio-facing: SURE-P at home; the YESSO/COPE/Fadama family and the Bank's South-South exchanges for the system layer; and the CGAP "graduation" literature (pilots in Ethiopia, Ghana, Haiti, Honduras, India, Pakistan, Peru and Yemen) for the livelihoods thinking beside the cash transfer (World Bank, 2016). The Rwanda (PSG) and Ghana (NEIP) programmes appear in this review only as later evaluative comparators (Sections 4.3 and 5.4), not as design influences. Where the record does not support a link an outline might wish, this review records the gap rather than manufacturing the link.

1.3 Was N-Power new, or was it consolidation?

The direct predecessor. SURE-P's Graduate Internship Scheme (2012-2015) is the clearest ancestor: introduced under the Jonathan administration as a post-subsidy-protest safety-net response; one-year, firm-based, graduates-only, at ₦18,000/month; 41,161 placements from 84,772 applicants across two phases of 50,000 and 100,000 places (Premium Times, 2013). It established the "pay graduates a monthly stipend while they are posted somewhere" logic. N-Power kept that logic intact and changed three things at once: roughly doubled the stipend (₦18,000 → ₦30,000), doubled the duration (one year → two), and, the change with the largest downstream consequences, moved the "somewhere" from private firms to public services, swapping a demand-side placement mechanism that absorbed graduates into existing employers for a supply-side deployment that posted them into understaffed schools, clinics and extension services. It also opened eligibility to non-graduates and lifted the scale target by an order of magnitude, to 500,000 (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Premium Times, 2013).

The predecessor the consolidation ignored is the more revealing one. YouWiN! (2012-2015) ran a business-plan competition awarding grants of roughly US$50,000 to about 1,200 winners drawn from more than 24,000 applicants, and was subjected to a randomized controlled trial that verified its outcomes: 7,027 jobs created, a 94% survival rate among funded firms against 60% among unfunded applicants, and a doubling of employment in new firms, figures from which a cost per job could actually be computed (McKenzie, 2017). N-Power's designers scaled up the predecessor with no published outcome evaluation (SURE-P), four hundred times past the best-evaluated one (YouWiN!). The choice is defensible on equity grounds, a stipend corps reaches far more people than a grant competition, but it carried a cost this review documents throughout: N-Power inherited SURE-P's absence of an outcome-verification culture at exactly the scale that most needed one (Premium Times, 2013; IPA & J-PAL, 2025; McKenzie, 2017).

Overall assessment (conclusion, flagged). N-Power was genuinely new in ambition, no Nigerian programme had attempted a half-million-person, all-774-LGA stipend-plus-deployment youth corps, but consolidation in mechanism. A programme launched as the anti-corruption successor to SURE-P reproduced SURE-P's central weakness, paying young people to be somewhere without a verified path from that somewhere to sustained work, at ten times the scale. Table 2 summarizes the comparator set; the pattern is consistent: each successive iteration scaled reach and per-beneficiary cost without a corresponding scale-up in independent evaluation.

Table 2. *N-Power's most direct predecessor and comparator programmes.*

Programme	Period	Duration	Stipend/grant	Scale	Independent evaluation
SURE-P Graduate Internship Scheme	2012-2015	1 year	₦18,000/mo.	41,161 of 84,772 applicants	No public final evaluation report (Premium Times, 2013)
YouWiN!	2012-2015	One-off grant	~US$50k avg	~1,200 winners of 24,000+ applicants	RCT-verified: 7,027 jobs; 94% vs 60% firm survival (McKenzie, 2017)
N-Power	2016-2024 (relaunched 2025-26)	2 years (now 1)	₦30,000/mo.	~500,000+ (A+B); ~1M claimed (C)	No tracer, RCT, or quasi-experimental design ever conducted (IPA & J-PAL, 2025)

2.0 STATED PURPOSE AND EVOLUTION

This section sets out N-Power's objectives as stated at launch, traces how they were operationalized across three enrolment batches, and asks whether the 2025-2026 "Renewed Hope" reframing is a genuine redesign or a rebrand of an unchanged mechanism.

2.1 The original objectives (2016)

The 2016 Information Guide states four objectives verbatim: (1) to intervene directly to improve the condition of a significant number of unemployed young Nigerians; (2) to establish a robust framework for the acquisition and transfer of employability, entrepreneurial and technical skills; (3) to create an ecosystem of solutions for deficiencies in public services and support government diversification; and (4) to foster the development and enhancement of the knowledge economy in Nigeria (N-Power Information Guide, 2017, reproduced in Osimen et al., 2025).

Design parameters: ₦30,000/month stipend; a two-year engagement; five sub-schemes (N-Teach, N-Health, N-Agro, N-Build, N-Tax/VAIDS); deployment across all 774 LGAs; a 500,000-person target (Batch A 200,000 + Batch B 300,000) (N-Power Information Guide, 2017).

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). These four objectives mix two different kinds of goal. Objectives 1-2 are individual objectives, improving a young person's livelihood and transferring skills to that person. Objectives 3-4 are system objectives, repairing understaffed public services and building a knowledge economy. A fixed monthly stipend paid to a volunteer posted to a school, clinic or farm is a reasonably direct instrument for the first pair; it is a much less direct instrument for the second pair, which would require sustained institutional absorption of volunteers into those systems well beyond the two-year placement. The dual mandate is present in the founding documents, not introduced by any later administrator, and it is why the programme could always report a deployment number (a system output) while never being able to report an employment number (an individual outcome). The mechanism that filled the schools was never the mechanism that would have moved the volunteer into a job. The founding documents describe the duration of the engagement far more precisely than the mechanism of the exit: no tracer, no placement service, no employer linkage was specified in 2016 (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; World Bank, 2016).

2.2 How the objectives were operationalized

- **Batch A.** Registration opened 12 June 2016; 200,000 selected; stipends began 1 December 2016 (Osimen et al., 2025).
- **Batch B.** A further 300,000 in 2017/18, bringing the corps to the 500,000 target (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; corroborated by Premium Times, 2019; Punch Newspapers, 2020).
- **Batch C.** Conceived as a million-person expansion: Stream 1 inaugurated at roughly 510,000; Stream 2 planned at a further 490,000 (Premium Times, 2019; TheCable, 2019, 2021; Punch Newspapers, 2020). What actually arrived was Stream 1's inauguration followed by a stalled Stream 2, a stalled NEXIT exit portal, and a cohort that flowed into arrears rather than into employment; Batch A and B exit dates (30 June and 31 July 2020) passed with no new enrolment for more than 1.5 years, and delays and enrolment extensions replaced a clean completion (Premium Times, 2019; Punch Newspapers, 2020). Stream 1 beneficiaries were still owed stipends into 2026 (NSIPA, 2026; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025).
- **Portfolio heterogeneity**. The 500,000 were not one programme but strands with genuinely different logics: N-Teach and N-Health (graduates, posted as teaching and primary-healthcare assistants), N-Agro (extension support), N-Build, N-Tax and VAIDS (vocational, technical and tax-liaison tracks) (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Osimen et al., 2025). A teaching assistant, an extension volunteer and a tax-liaison officer received the same ₦30,000 for the same nominal two years while doing different work with different exit prospects, and the design provided no strand-specific outcome frame to tell them apart. At the 2023-2026 juncture the documented sub-scheme totals are 900,000 N-Teach and 150,000 N-Health "since inception": N-Teach dominates by a factor of six, which makes the programme's public-service impact, objective 3, overwhelmingly an education-sector story, whatever the five-sub-scheme branding suggests. No source explains whether this imbalance was designed or emergent (NSIPA, 2026).

Table 3. *Batch history: claimed reach and delivery status. The pattern from Batch A to Batch C is increasing scale claims accompanied by decreasing certainty about delivery.*

Batch	**Year**	**Claimed reach**	**Status**	**Key sources**
Batch A	2016	200,000	Consistently corroborated across official and press sources	N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Premium Times, 2019; Osimen et al., 2025
Batch B	2017/18	300,000	Broadly corroborated; extension reporting notes delays	N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Punch Newspapers, 2020
Batch C, Stream 1	2020	510,000 (inaugurated)	Inauguration reported; independent verification of full deployment not found; cohort later in arrears	Premium Times, 2019; TheCable, 2019, 2021; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025
Batch C, Stream 2	Planned	490,000 (planned)	Not confirmed as completed in the public record; arrears of ₦108bn to 400,000 beneficiaries documented in 2024	TheCable, 2019, 2021; Punch Newspapers, 2020; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). The operational drift was structural, not incidental: the programme scaled the input it could control, names on a payroll, faster than the delivery it could not: timely payment and a managed exit. Enlarging the corps enlarged the arrears and the ghost-payroll exposure that the suspension would later expose. By Batch C, the two-year exit-to-employment framework was neither two years in practice nor an exit to employment; it had become an open-ended stipend liability with no transition attached.

2.3 The Renewed Hope reframing

Documented (facts). The programme was renamed the Renewed Hope Job Creation Programme in October 2023 (Africa Check, 2023). Three concrete changes are visible on the current record: NSIPA's programme page now describes N-Teach and N-Health as one-year programmes (the original two-year duration halved); the same page records cumulative deployments of 900,000 N-Teach and 150,000 N-Health "since inception"; and a vocational and skills track was flagged off in 2026 for 18,000 Phase-1 trainees across fourteen trades, with 100,000+ items distributed at a reported ₦32.7bn (NSIPA, 2026). A five-million-beneficiary target circulates on ministry social channels (NSIPA, 2026). The minister's public language frames a redirection, "review and reform," linking youth to "market space and the private sector" (Premium Times, 2025; FMHAPA, 2026). A separate HoPE-CT cash-transfer stream (₦75,000 × 15 million households) runs alongside (NSIPA, 2026; FMHAPA, 2026). The February 2026 assurance is that "all verified N-Power beneficiaries who are owed outstanding payments will receive them" (NSIPA, 2026; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025).

Opaque (facts about absence). The duration change appears on the agency website without a published announcement, rationale or transition arrangement for beneficiaries caught between regimes. The five-million target carries no costed implementation plan, no results framework and no published baseline, it exists as a claim, not a document, and the specific ministry post stating it remains unverified, so it is cited at institutional level only. The stipend is unchanged at ₦30,000. No published tracer or outcome study for Batches A, B or C precedes the relaunch. The 2026 registration portal runs on non-government Firebase hosting rather than gov.ng infrastructure (NSIPA, 2026).

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). Precision about the word "reframing" matters. A genuine redesign would be evidenced by a published theory of change, revised targeting criteria, or a stated rationale for the duration change. None appears in the matrix. What appears is a change of name, of headline duration, and of portal hosting, changes visible to a citizen registering, which do not reach the underlying mechanics of stipend value, targeting or evaluation. The February 2026 arrears assurance confirms the direction of travel: the reset is gating old payments on a "verification" the programme never previously enforced, constructing at the point of the arrears, a decade late, the identity check the 2016 design named as foundational (NSIPA, 2026; World Bank, 2016). A rebrand is not a redesign.

2.4 Is it answering the same question?

- The 2016 question was acute graduate unemployment in a recession: combined youth unemployment-and-underemployment at 52.65%, graduates' distress expanding 31% in a year (APC, 2015; NBS, 2017). A stipend-plus-deployment model was a plausible, if partial, response.
- The 2026 question, on the regional evidence base, is different: the ILO and Mastercard Foundation frame the African youth-employment problem around informality and working poverty rather than headline joblessness, 90% of Africa's employed youth work informally; NEET affects more than one in four; only ~3 million formal jobs are created for the 10 million+ young Africans entering the labour market each year (ILO, 2026; Mastercard Foundation, 2026).

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). This is the most consequential open question the review can raise without being able to close: not whether N-Power delivered what it promised in 2016, but whether what it promised in 2016 is still the right thing to promise in 2026. Two discontinuities compound it. First, measurement: the NBS series on which the 2016 baseline rests (20-hour threshold) was revised in 2014 and discontinued after 2020, while the ILO-modelled series (1-hour threshold) paints a materially different picture, so the "same question" cannot even be posed against a continuous instrument (see Table 6, row 1). Second, function: in 2016 the programme was a relief instrument presented as a jobs solution, and the gap was tolerable while the stipend still bought something and recovery was expected; by 2026 the stipend buys little (Section 4.5), the recovery did not produce the graduate jobs assumed, and the reset's own language has shifted the goal toward private-sector linkage and vocational trades, a different theory of change attached to the same unindexed stipend and the same unverified reach (NSIPA, 2026; NBS, 2017; ILO, 2026; Mastercard Foundation, 2026). Whether the partly new question can be answered depends on whether the reset supplies the three things the 2016 design left out: an indexed transfer value, a published results framework, and a post-exit tracer.

3.0 EXPECTATION VERSUS REALITY

This is the longest section of the review, because it is where the gap between official narrative and independently verifiable evidence is widest. It proceeds from the programme's stated promises, through reach and employment-outcome evidence, to the distributional record, and closes by ranking the three gaps that structure the necessity assessment in Section 4.

3.1 What N-Power promised

Three promises, each stated in the official record as a measurable commitment (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Osimen et al., 2025):

- Reach. 500,000 young unemployed graduates across Batches A and B at launch, expanding toward a million as Batch C was conceived; framed as "the largest post-tertiary engagement of human resources in Africa" (N-Power Information Guide, 2017).
- Employment. An explicitly transitional promise: the programme was "designed to provide both graduates and non-graduates with essential skills, resources, and opportunities to move from unemployment to gainful employment, entrepreneurship, and innovation," with the two-year ₦30,000 stipend as the vehicle and an NEXIT portal as the exit mechanism (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Punch Newspapers, 2020; Osimen et al., 2025).
- Sectoral coverage. Volunteers as support teachers (N-Teach), community health workers (N-Health), agricultural extension advisers (N-Agro), building trades (N-Build), and community tax-liaison officers (N-Tax/VAIDS); N-Teach and N-Health reserved for graduates who had completed the NYSC year (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Osimen et al., 2025).

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). The promise that matters most is the second, and the asymmetry between promise types is the design's central fault line. The reach target is an input promise, names on a payroll are administratively countable. The employment promise is an outcome promise; lives moved into sustained work are countable only with a tracer that follows beneficiaries past exit. The founding documents specify the stipend and duration in detail but describe the exit-to-employment mechanism only as an expectation, not as a built pipeline (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; World Bank, 2016). The programme therefore promised, in the same breath, a thing it could easily report and a thing it had made no institutional provision to measure. The decade that followed reproduced that asymmetry exactly.

3.2 Reach claims vs. verifiable evidence

The claim series (facts). Batch A: 200,000 selected, stipends from 1 December 2016. Batch B: a further 300,000 in 2017/18. Batch C: Stream 1 inaugurated ≈510,000; Stream 2 ≈490,000 planned. Cumulative sub-scheme totals "since inception": 900,000 N-Teach; 150,000 N-Health. On the official record, N-Power's reach climbed from half a million to a cumulative figure well above one million (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; NSIPA, 2026; Premium Times, 2019; TheCable, 2019, 2021; Punch Newspapers, 2020; Osimen et al., 2025).

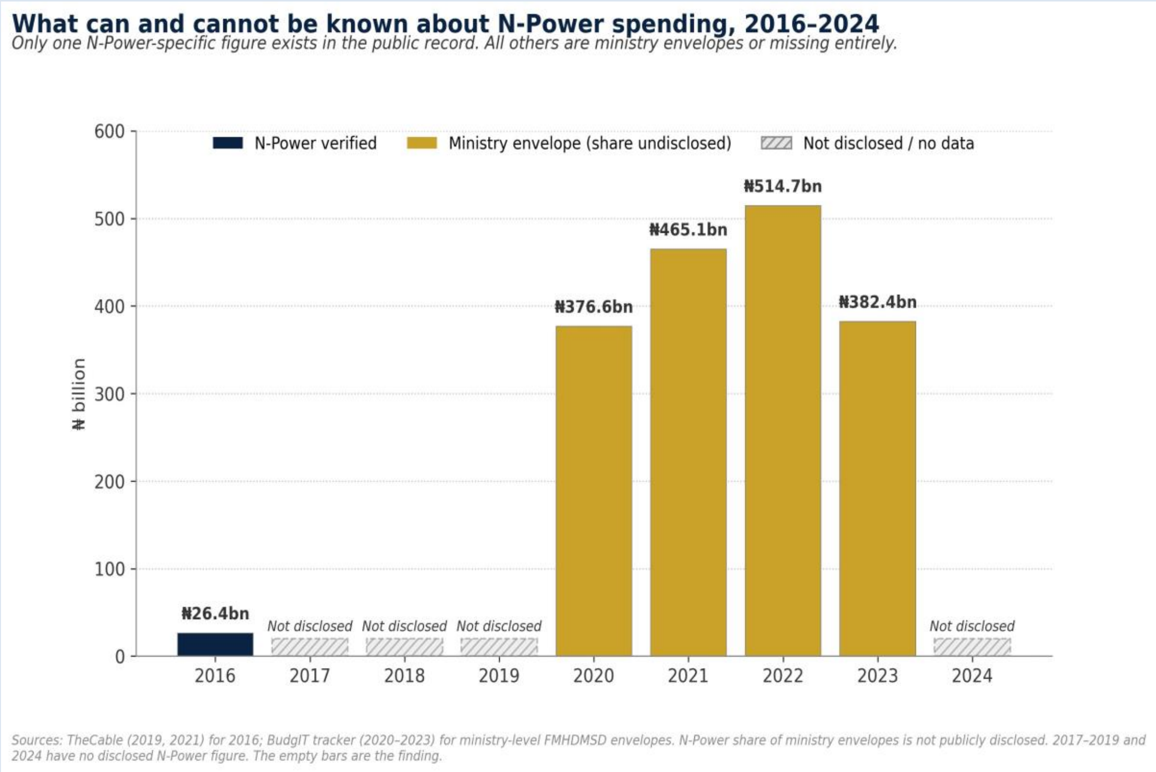
The qualification comes from three directions (findings).

First, the fiscal record. In 2016 the Federal Government budgeted ₦500 billion for the social-investment programme; only about ₦41 billion had been expended by May, of which roughly ₦26 billion (₦26.418bn) reached N-Power specifically; the programme's monthly stipend bill on a 500,000 corps runs ≈ ₦15 billion (Federal Ministry of Budget and National Planning, 2016; BudgIT, 2020-2024; TheCable, 2019, 2021). BudgIT's tracking shows the same pattern across the period, allocation exceeding release exceeding utilization, with disbursement opacity and no public M&E dashboard against which a citizen could reconcile a budget line to a beneficiary (BudgIT, 2020-2024).

Second, the payroll was contaminated. Sahara Reporters' December 2022 reporting, based on unnamed sources around an ICPC investigation, stated that 70,000 ghost names had been infused into N-Power over four years at a cost of ₦2.1 billion a year, and that a further 20,000 names on the so-called "D'banj's list" diverted ₦600 million a month for more than two years, while 14,000 genuine beneficiaries were owed five months of stipends as of June 2021 (Sahara Reporters, 2022). These figures are material, but they should be treated as investigative-journalism estimates rather than audited ICPC counts, because no published ICPC dataset or audit containing the figures has *been located. The individual associated with the second list, D'banj, was subsequently cleared by the ICPC in November 2023, with the commission stating that there was no prima facie case of fraud against him. That clearance resolves the individual allegation, but it does not erase the wider payroll-contamination evidence. TheCable's undercover reporting separately documented the mechanics of fraud, including ₦8,000 redeployment bribes, 50/50 stipend-sharing with impersonators, 363 ghosts in Kwara State alone, and the disengagement of more than 2,500 fraudulent beneficiaries (TheCable, 2019, 2021). A further 2,000+ beneficiaries were reported disengaged during the 2024 audit (Guardian Nigeria, 2024). Denominator honesty: 90,000 reported ghost names against the 500,000 Batch A+B figure is about 18%; against the roughly 1.0m Batch A+B+C claim it is about 9%. The 9-18% range is this reviewer's arithmetic on sourced figures, and should be read as an indicative range from available reporting, not as an audited payroll count. Third, independent verification does not exist. No independent national enrolment audit, no state-disaggregated mapping, and no dedicated N-Power tracker has ever been published by any body reviewed, including the data-journalism outlets (BudgIT, 2020-2024; HumAngle & Dataphyte, 2025). The claim of deployment across all 774 LGAs rests on a single official assertion, not an independently verified dataset (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; HumAngle & Dataphyte, 2025).*

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). The fraud finding is one of the best-supported in this review because it recurs across three independent source types, investigative journalism (TheCable, 2019, 2021), an anti-corruption agency action (Sahara Reporters, 2022), and legislative oversight (Nigerian Tribune, 2025), a stronger triangulation than most other claims here can draw on. Fraud in the beneficiary payroll was real, persistent across multiple years, and large enough to prompt formal criminal investigation. But even the most corroborated part of the reach claim, the initial enrolment numbers, cannot be treated as a clean count of real, paid, working beneficiaries.

Chart 1: *Federal budget allocation vs. actual disbursement, 2016-2024*



The 2020-2023 figures are ministry-level envelopes (FMHDMSD), not N-Power-specific allocations; the chart must label them as such or restrict to N-Power series pending extraction (Annex E, item E2). A supplementary series worth plotting if extractable: monthly stipend bill ≈ ₦15bn on a 500,000 corps (TheCable, 2019, 2021).

3.3 Employment outcome evidence

The one measured result (finding). The only published impact study this review can locate is Osimen et al. (2025): a cross-sectional survey of 99 N-Power beneficiaries in Lagos State, drawn by Taro Yamane's formula from a stated Lagos beneficiary population of about 10,130, with a 76.8% response rate, analyzed by linear regression (Osimen et al., 2025). Its headline result is that N-Power explains 14.5% of the variance in self-reported youth empowerment ($R = 0.381$; $R^2 = 0.145$; $F = 16.464$; $p < 0.05$; $B = 0.348$), statistically significant, but modest: 85.5% of the variation in the measured outcome is explained by something other than the programme.

The raw employment picture in that same sample is more telling than the regression (finding). At the time of the survey, of the 99 respondents: 41.4% were unemployed, 31.3% self-employed, 20.2% still students, and only 7.1% in wage employment (Osimen et al., 2025). A programme whose stated purpose was to move beneficiaries "from unemployment to gainful employment" thus left, in its only measured sample, four in ten respondents without work. The study's key-informant testimony shows the same dispersion in words: a VAIDS beneficiary reported that "after completing the program, many of us went back home without nothing to start with … going back to square one," while an N-Agro beneficiary described building a poultry farm of over 1,000 birds from stipend savings, the same programme producing both outcomes within a single 99-person sample (Osimen et al., 2025).

What this means and does not mean (conclusion, flagged). An R^2 of 0.145 means that within a sample of 99 Lagos participants, participation is a statistically real but modest predictor of one self-reported empowerment measure. It does not mean the programme is ineffective; and the 41.4% unemployment figure is a snapshot of respondents at the moment of questioning, not a tracer of ex-beneficiaries over time. The correct reading is narrower than either N-Power's critics or its defenders tend to offer: this is the only rigorous outcome estimate that exists, it is positive-but-small on its chosen measure and discouraging on raw employment status, and it cannot be generalized beyond Lagos in either direction (Osimen et al., 2025).

The wider literature does not rescue the picture; it confirms its thinness (finding). Every other located study is small, single-state, and without a control group or sustained-employment tracer: Abin (2018, Nasarawa) found improved socioeconomic status and beneficiaries "overwhelmingly pleased," alongside unpaid and late stipends; Bisong (2019, Cross River) found the programme "significantly generated employment opportunities"; Komolafe et al. (2022) found N-Agro had a "tangible impact" on income in Lagos; Afolabi (2020) claimed N-Power "created over 5,000 jobs", a single, uncorroborated figure with no stated methodology (all cited within Osimen et al., 2025). None is a tracer study in the sense the employment promise requires: none followed a cohort into the labour market after exit and measured sustained employment at 6, 12 or 24 months.

The official claims sit uneasily against this (finding). A Ministry key informant in the Osimen study called N-Power "one of the best ever implemented since … 1999," asserting that "many of our trainees today are economically empowered, self-employed and also employer of labour" (Osimen et al., 2025), stakeholder opinion, attributed. But the official record contains no published, audited employment-outcome figure anywhere: the agency reports enrolments, deployments and disbursements, and publishes no number for how many beneficiaries moved into sustained work after exit (NSIPA, 2026). A ministry official at launch promised an exit-strategy package for 300,000 exiting beneficiaries (Punch Newspapers, 2020); the NEXIT portal created for the purpose stalled (Premium Times, 2019; Punch Newspapers, 2020).

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). The gap here is not between a high official employment figure and a low independent one; it is between official rhetoric of employment success and the absence of any official employment measurement at all. The active-labour-market evaluation standard, randomized or quasi-experimental design with tracer surveys at 6/12/24 months, has never been applied to N-Power; no tracer study of any batch has been conducted at national scale; no cost-per-job or cost-per-sustained-employment figure exists (IPA & J-PAL, 2025). That absence is the central finding of this subsection. The measurement gap is not a footnote to N-Power's performance story, it is the performance story.

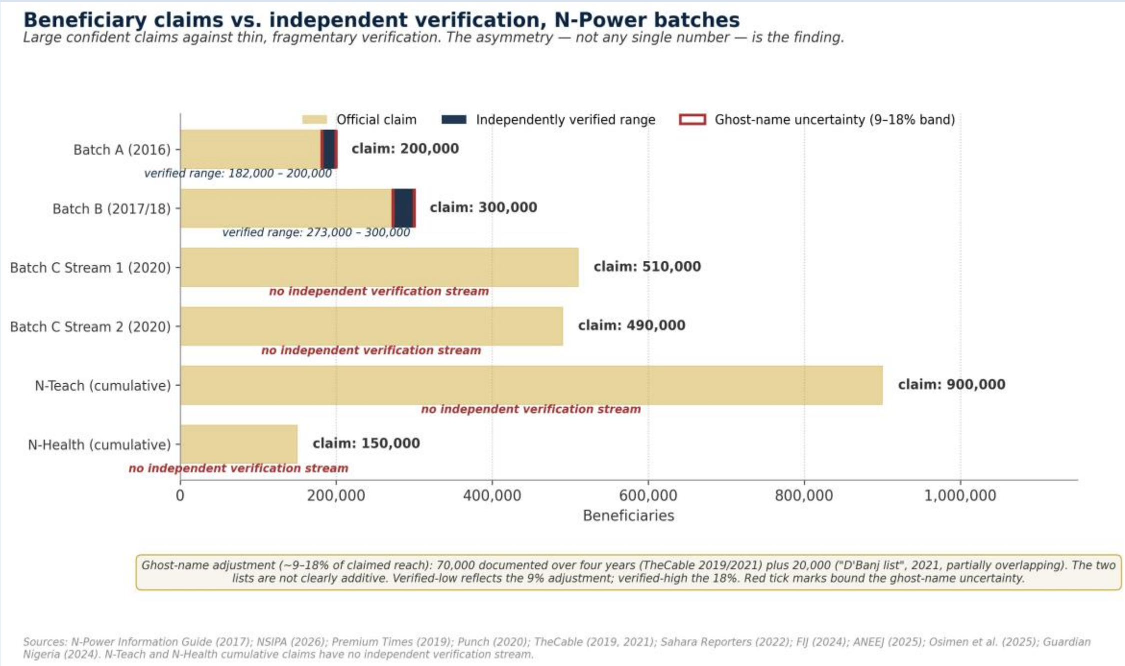
3.4 Distributional analysis

What is not published (finding about absence). No source disaggregates N-Power's beneficiaries by state, LGA, gender at national level, or rural-urban location; the agency's public reporting gives cumulative strand totals only (NSIPA, 2026). No data-journalism outlet has published an independent state-level mapping (HumAngle & Dataphyte, 2025). This absence is recorded here as a reporting-integrity finding in its own right, carried to Section 5.

What can be said with sources (findings). On sub-scheme reach: N-Teach dominates nationally (900,000 vs 150,000 N-Health, per NSIPA, 2026), and the Lagos sample corroborates the plurality (N-Teach 40.4%, N-Agro 37.4%, N-Health 18.1%, VAIDS 4.0%, Osimen et al., 2025). On gender: the Lagos sample is near-balanced (46.5% male, 48.5% female, 5.1% declined), a single-state figure, not generalizable (Osimen et al., 2025). Note, to prevent conflation: the strong female-targeting design in the social-investment architecture belongs to the World Bank-financed cash transfer, not to N-Power (World Bank, 2016). On geography: the design posted beneficiaries to "principal assignments within their local government of home," implying a home-LGA distribution, but no published breakdown exists to verify how it fell (Osimen et al., 2025).

The geography of need is well mapped, and the comparison cannot be made (finding). In Q3 2017, unemployment was predominantly southern and urban (Rivers highest at 41.82%; urban 23.4% vs rural 16.4%), while underemployment was predominantly northern and rural (Katsina highest at 46.19%; rural 26.9% vs urban 9.0%). The five states with the largest combined distressed populations, Rivers (2.64m), Lagos (2.33m), Kaduna (1.99m), Kano (1.90m), Akwa Ibom (1.81m), together held 31.14% of the national total (NBS, 2017). Whether N-Power's deployment matched that geography of need cannot be determined from the published record, because the programme never published the distribution that would allow the comparison.

Chart 2: *Beneficiary claims vs. verifiable reach, Batches A-C*



Render the ghost overlay as an uncertainty band, not a point. The 70,000 and 20,000 figures come from investigative reporting and are not clearly additive or mutually exclusive. The chart's message is the asymmetry: large official reach claims against thin, fragmentary independent verification. Do not present the ghost-name figures as an audited count.

3.5 The gap between promise and delivery

Ranking the gaps is the analytical payoff of the section, and the ranking is itself an analytical judgment (flagged as such), a synthesis of how much independent corroboration stands behind each claim rather than a figure drawn from any single source.

- Largest gap: the employment transition. The central promise and the least measurable delivery. No tracer counts the transition; the single measured sample found 41.4% still unemployed; the official record offers enrolment counts and success rhetoric but no outcome number. The gap is not between two figures but between a promise and a measurement that does not exist (NSIPA, 2026; Osimen et al., 2025; IPA & J-PAL, 2025).
- Medium gap: the batch scale-up. The million-person Batch C delivered an inaugurated Stream 1, a stalled Stream 2, and a cohort that flowed into arrears; the January 2024 suspension froze the programme mid-scale-up (Premium Times, 2019; TheCable, 2019, 2021; Punch Newspapers, 2020; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025).
- Smallest gap: initial reach. Batch A (200,000) and Batch B (300,000) are the most corroborated numbers in the programme's history, corroborated as numbers across the official guide, the agency and the press, though not as clean counts of real, paid, working beneficiaries once the ghost-payroll evidence is read in (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Premium Times, 2019; Punch Newspapers, 2020; Sahara Reporters, 2022). Readers who weight the fraud evidence more heavily than this review does may reasonably rank this gap larger than "smallest."

Ordered conclusion: the programme delivered its inputs most faithfully, its scale-up partially, and its defining outcome not at all, and it cannot report the outcome because it never built the instrument to measure it.

4.0 NECESSITY ASSESSMENT

Having established what N-Power promised and what the record can verify, this section asks the harder normative question: given actual delivery, is the programme, or something like it, still needed, and in what form?

4.1 Given actual delivery, is the programme still necessary?

The question must be split before it can be answered (conclusion, flagged). N-Power was never one intervention but two bundled together, and the evidence points in opposite directions for each.

The stipend-provision function, a monthly cash transfer to unemployed young people, retains, and has if anything strengthened, the case for necessity. Beneficiaries describe the stipend in relief terms: an N-Teach key informant reported "the monthly stipends of 30,000 naira helped many of us to finance some family basic needs" (Osimen et al., 2025, attributed testimony). Nigeria's economy remains recession-prone; the World Bank's appraisal makes the consumption-smoothing case explicitly, noting that regular transfers let poor households "make economic decisions driven by long-term efficiency rather than short-term contingencies" (World Bank, 2016). The relief function is necessary.

The skills-transfer-to-employment function has not, as currently designed, made the case. The only outcome evaluation found 14.5% of variance explained and 41.4% of its sample still unemployed; there is no tracer, no placement service and no employer linkage in the design (Osimen et al., 2025; N-Power Information Guide, 2017; World Bank, 2016). No study has isolated the skills-transfer or deployment mechanism as the active ingredient, as opposed to the cash component.

Why the distinction matters for policy (conclusion, flagged). If the active ingredient is the cash, a simpler, cheaper-to-administer transfer might achieve similar welfare effects at lower fraud risk. If the active ingredient is the deployment experience, investment should concentrate on placement quality and public-service absorption. The evidence base cannot adjudicate between the two, because no study has attempted to isolate them, an outstanding research question registered in Annex E. Necessity, on current evidence, attaches to the transfer, not to the unverified transition.

4.2 Nigerian youth unemployment in 2026 vs. 2016

The 2016 baseline is well documented (facts). Combined youth (15-35) unemployment-and-underemployment of 52.65% (22.64m) in Q3 2017, up from 45.65% a year earlier; headline unemployment rising from 12.1% (Q1 2016) to 18.8% (Q3 2017); graduates at 31.8%/50.0%, with the distressed graduate cohort expanding from 4.97m to 6.53m in twelve months (NBS, 2017).

A clean 2016-to-2026 comparison on a single instrument does not exist (finding, and a data-quality finding). The NBS series (20-hour threshold, revised 2014) was discontinued after 2020; the most recent NBS anchor is 20.1% unemployment for Q1 2023 on the revised methodology, which is not continuous with the older series; and the World Bank ILO-modelled series (1-hour threshold) reports youth (15-24) unemployment of 8.99% (2021), 6.02% (2022), 5.09% (2024) and 5.34% (2025), a downward trend measuring a different thing (Osimen et al., 2025; NBS, 2017; World Bank, 2022-2025). This NBS-vs-ILO divergence is a named contradiction (Table 6, row 1), not a resolved one. This review will not interpolate a trend across the break.

What can be said without fabrication (assessment, flagged). The structural conditions the 2016 baseline captured, a large graduate cohort, a recession-prone economy, a private sector that absorbs few of the poor into wage work, were not transient. The 2016 appraisal recorded that half the workforce remained in low-productivity agriculture, that "the poor are least likely to work in wage jobs," and that household enterprises faced "skill deficits, poor access to finance, poor infrastructure, limited access to markets, and the lack of a legal or regulatory framework" (World Bank, 2016). The regional literature reframes 2026's binding problem as informality and working poverty: 90% informality, NEET above 25%, ~3m formal jobs for 10m+ annual labour-market entrants, with services set to overtake agriculture as the primary youth employer by 2033 (ILO, 2026; Mastercard Foundation, 2026). The necessity case rests on the persistence of those structural conditions, not on a precise 2026 rate the record cannot supply. Two specifics remain unextracted and are registered in Annex E: a 2026 graduate-population denominator (from NBS, 2017 row) and any time-series on private-sector absorption capacity.

4.3 Alternatives

Domestic public alternatives are real but thinly documented, and share the defects (finding). The National Directorate of Employment and SMEDAN run comparator programmes at orders-of-magnitude smaller scale with fragmented coordination: NDE's cited example trained 1,000 youths in a single Katsina cohort; SMEDAN's Conditional Grant Scheme provides ₦50,000 per nano-business conditional on employing at least one person; no unified national tracker links these programmes to N-Power or to each other (NDE & SMEDAN, 2025). The one quantified datum this review holds on NDE is itself a warning: average actual spending was 69.1% of total budget (World Bank, 2016), the same chronic under-disbursement that afflicted N-Power. The 2016 appraisal's sector diagnosis applies to the whole class: "poor targeting, undefined eligibility criteria, lack of monitoring and evaluation systems, and absence of a management information system" (World Bank, 2016). The alternative to N-Power is not a well-functioning public machine but a set of institutions sharing its defects. A fuller NDE/ITF comparison is an outstanding extraction (Annex E, item E3).

The better-documented alternative is a model, not a programme (finding). The CGAP "graduation" pilots, run across eight countries (Ethiopia, Ghana, Haiti, Honduras, India, Pakistan, Peru and Yemen) and evaluated with randomized controlled trials, combined consumption support with a productive asset, skills training and savings: two years after the programme, beneficiaries earned 33% more than non-beneficiaries and consumed 5% more per capita, with returns on investment from 120% in Ghana to 420% in India (World Bank, 2016). That is the documented counterfactual to N-Power's stipend-alone approach, and the template the same appraisal built into Nigeria's own cash-transfer design: a transfer paired with an asset and mentoring, with the result measured, against N-Power's transfer with neither asset nor measurement.

International comparators show scale is no excuse for missing evidence (finding). Rwanda's Priority Skills for Growth trained approximately 24,000 people (more than one-third women) with 82% reporting employment or self-employment, a verified figure at roughly 1/20th of N-Power's scale (World Bank, 2026). Ghana's NEIP targets 10,000 sustainable businesses a year; its outcomes are not independently verified in the matrix (NEIP, 2026). And the domestic YouWiN! RCT verified 7,027 jobs at 1/400th of N-Power's scale (McKenzie, 2017).

Table 4. *International and domestic comparator programmes. The comparison is deliberately not scaled to cost or reach parity, the point is evaluative rigor, not size. A programme twenty times smaller produced a verified result; N-Power, at vastly greater scale and cost, has produced none in ten years.*

Programme	Scale	Verified outcome	M&E design
N-Power (Nigeria)	~500,000-1M+ claimed	None independently verified	No tracer, no control group, no cost-effectiveness calculation (IPA & J-PAL, 2025)
Rwanda Priority Skills for Growth	~24,000 trained	82% employed/self-employed	World Bank-monitored results reporting (World Bank, 2026)
Ghana NEIP	Target 10,000 businesses/yr	Not independently verified in matrix	Programme-level target only (NEIP, 2026)
YouWiN! (Nigeria)	~1,200 winners	7,027 jobs; 94% vs 60% survival	Randomized controlled trial (McKenzie, 2017)
NDE / SMEDAN (Nigeria)	Small, fragmented cohorts (e.g., 1,000 in one NDE cohort)	No published outcome data	No unified tracker; siloed reporting (NDE & SMEDAN, 2025)
CGAP graduation pilots (8 countries)	Small pilots	+33% earnings, +5% consumption at 2 years; ROI 120-420%	Randomized controlled trials (World Bank, 2016)

4.4 The case for continuation, restructuring, or discontinuation

- Continuation case: a countercyclical stipend safety net has modest empirical support (Osimen et al., 2025) and demonstrated political durability across two administrations (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; NSIPA, 2026).
- Restructuring case: retain the transfer and the sub-schemes with the clearest participant-reported signal (N-Teach, N-Agro, Osimen et al., 2025); rebuild the rest around the evaluated cash-plus-livelihoods model (World Bank, 2016); index the stipend (Section 4.5); instrument the exit (Section 8).

- Discontinuation case: an approximate unit cost of ₦360,000/year per beneficiary (₦30,000 × 12, reviewer arithmetic, flagged as derived) against zero independently verified employment-transition outcomes, a payroll carrying up to 90,000 documented ghost names, and a stipend eroded to a fraction of its 2016 value raises a legitimate opportunity-cost question (IPA & J-PAL, 2025; Sahara Reporters, 2022).

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). This review weighs the three cases rather than pre-empting Section 8, and the evidence supports restructuring over either continuation as-is or discontinuation: continuation as-is is indefensible because the skills-transfer half has not demonstrated effectiveness and the stipend half has been silently eroded; discontinuation is indefensible because the relief function remains necessary in a recession-prone economy and the documented sub-schemes show real, if localized, gains. A structural point disciplines all three cases: none of continuation, restructuring or discontinuation can be responsibly chosen without the outcome data that Section 3.3 shows does not exist. The necessity question is presently unanswerable on the merits, and the most defensible near-term position is to build the measurement infrastructure needed to answer it, regardless of which long-run path is ultimately taken.

4.5 The stipend erosion

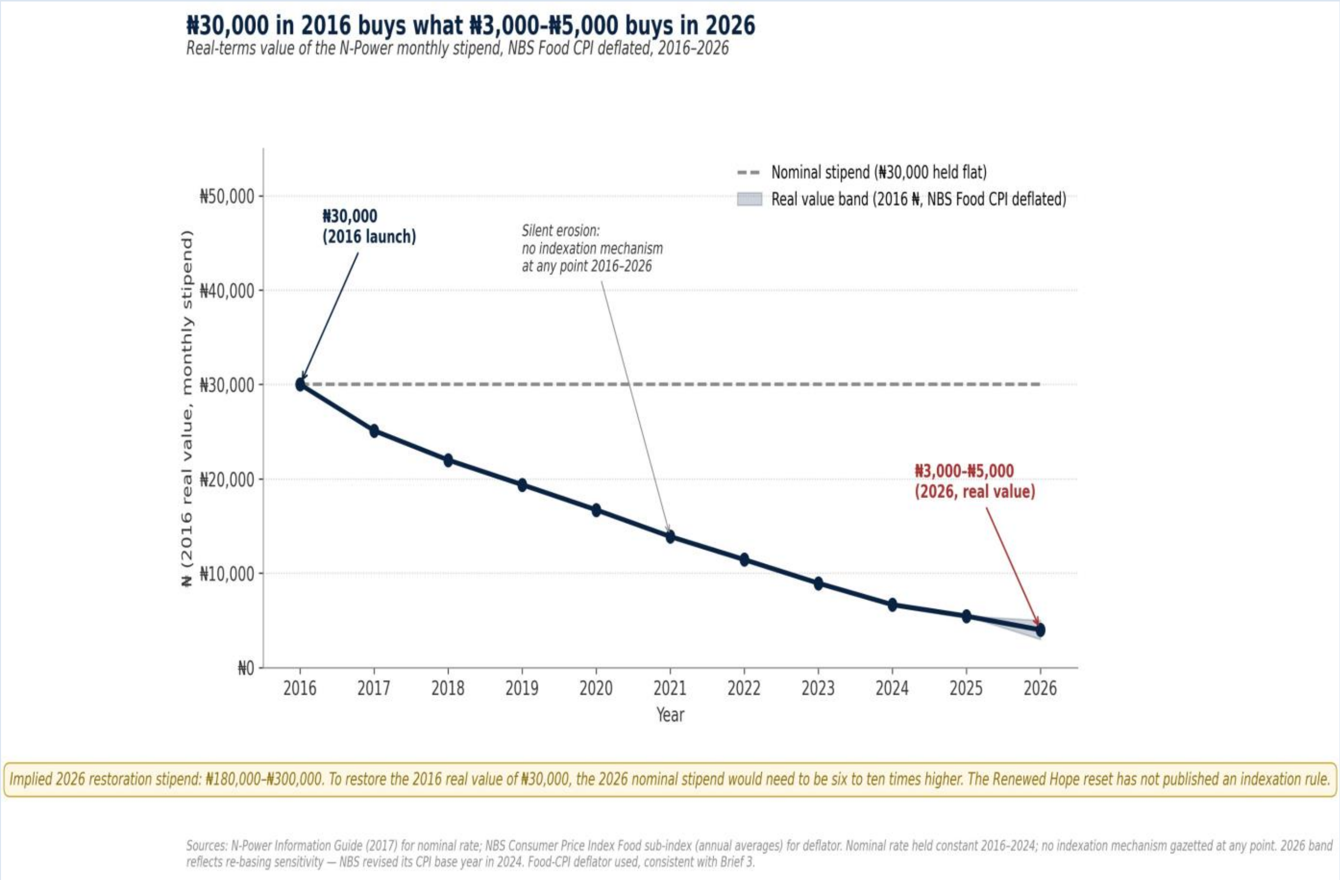
Facts. The ₦30,000 monthly stipend was set in 2016 and held nominally constant through 2026, on the agency's own current programme page, with no indexation mechanism written into the design (N-Power Information Guide, 2017; NSIPA, 2026). Over the same window food prices rose steeply: food inflation of 26.08% year-on-year in January 2025, 21.26% in April 2025, 21.14% in May 2025 and 14.31% in March 2026, on a consumer-price series the NBS re-based to 2024 = 100 (headline CPI peaked at 34.19% in June 2024) (NBS, 2026).

The sharpest contrast (finding). The companion World Bank-financed design-built indexation into its transfer principles as binding doctrine: "the transfer value must be appropriately related to the project objectives and have the capacity to adjust, as necessary, to reflect inflation and cost increases (such as … automatic adjustment according to an agreed-upon index, such as the Consumer Price Index)" (World Bank, 2016). The architecture Nigeria borrowed contained the very protection the domestically designed N-Power stipend omitted. The erosion was not an accident of economics; it was the consequence of a design choice, the same defect this series documented for the Home-Grown School Feeding meal allowance in Brief 3.

The magnitude, stated honestly as a band (finding, derived figures flagged). Deflated by the food index, the 2016 ₦30,000 retains an estimated ₦3,000 to ₦5,000 of its original purchasing power by 2026, roughly one-sixth to one-tenth of its launch value. The single defensible ratio is reserved for Chart 3 pending extraction of the 2016 base-month food-price level, because the 2024 re-base breaks a clean level-to-level comparison across the decade (methodology in Section 7.4). The inverse gives the restoration figure: to match 2016 real value, the 2026 stipend would need to be on the order of ₦180,000-₦300,000 a month, six to ten times the current figure (derived, provisional, same deflator caveat).

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). This is, in the reviewer's judgment, the most concrete and least contestable finding in the review. Unlike the reach and outcome questions, which depend on contested or thin evidence, it rests on two facts disputed nowhere in the record: the nominal stipend has not changed since 2016, and food prices have risen substantially over the same period. Whatever view one takes of N-Power's broader effectiveness, a beneficiary receiving the same ₦30,000 today is, in real terms, receiving a small fraction of what a Batch A beneficiary received in 2016: a transfer that bought a month of food in 2016 buys a few days in 2026. The stipend erosion is thus both a quantified welfare loss and a design indictment, and the empirical foundation for the indexation recommendation (Section 8, R1).

Chart 3: *Real-terms value of the ₦30,000 monthly N-Power stipend, NBS Food CPI deflated, 2016-2026]*



Deflator choice is consequential: the food sub-index is used (consistent with Brief 3 and appropriate for a consumption-dominated stipend); a headline-CPI deflator would yield a different figure. The chart must carry the re-base break and the band annotation visibly, or the erosion will be overstated into false precision.

5.0 DATA QUALITY AND REPORTING INTEGRITY

This section turns from what N-Power has delivered to how well the reporting system allows anyone, citizen, legislator or researcher, to know what it has delivered. The finding is consistent across every sub-section: the system reports outputs, not outcomes, and does so without the disaggregation needed for independent scrutiny.

5.1 What is publicly available

Findings. The public surface of N-Power reporting is a single programme page. It states the stipend (₦30,000/month), the current duration (now one year for N-Teach and N-Health), and two cumulative deployment totals "since inception" (900,000 N-Teach; 150,000 N-Health), alongside a six-department agency menu (NSIPA, 2026). It contains no dashboard, and it disaggregates nothing, not by state, LGA, batch, sub-scheme, quarter or gender. The only disaggregated N-Power data anywhere in the record is one academic survey of 99 beneficiaries in one state, which is not an official product (Osimen et al., 2025). Reporting is event-driven, ministerial statements, renamed programme pages, social-media claims such as the unverified five-million target, rather than scheduled; no quarterly bulletin, no annual results publication exists (NSIPA, 2026). The 2016 NSIP Framework Document itself flagged the absence of any public annual report carrying a full indicator series (Federal Ministry of Budget and National Planning, 2016).

Independent corroboration of the absence (finding). This is not an inference drawn from silence. The most authoritative independent assessment available, the World Bank's November 2025 review of Nigeria's social safety nets, records weak monitoring and evaluation, poor transparency, fragmented implementation and the absence of published audited accounts across the agency that administers N-Power, even as that agency accounts for 87% of the federal social-safety-net budget; Nigeria spends 0.14% of GDP on social safety nets against 1.1% for Sub-Saharan Africa, and programme coverage fell from 19% of the population (2018/19) to about 6% (2023) (World Bank, 2025). Requests for the missing series through available channels went unanswered within the review period (Section 7.5).

5.2 Output focus vs. outcome focus

What the official record measures (finding). Inputs and outputs: beneficiaries enrolled, volunteers deployed, cumulative strand totals, stipends meant to be paid (NSIPA, 2026). Even these are compromised as measures, because the payroll they count was found contaminated (up to 90,000 documented ghost names; 2,500+ disengaged) and because payment timeliness was broken by multi-year arrears (₦81bn approved 2022-23 unpaid; ₦108bn owed by 2024; ~1.5m beneficiaries still owed as of early 2026) (NSIPA, 2026; TheCable, 2019, 2021; Sahara Reporters, 2022; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025; curated beneficiary testimony, 2020-2026).

What the official record does not measure (finding). No published figure exists for: beneficiaries moved into sustained employment after exit; earnings gained; the sectoral effect of N-Teach/N-Health/N-Agro deployment on the schools, clinics and extension services they staffed; or cost per outcome of any kind (NSIPA, 2026; IPA & J-PAL, 2025). The single outcome-adjacent datapoint in the entire record is the Lagos survey, sub-national, academic, no control group, no tracer (Osimen et al., 2025). The official record is output-only, and even its outputs are unverified; the outcome layer that would tell a reader whether the programme did what it promised is, on the government's own publications, empty.

5.3 The measurement gap by Theory-of-Change level

The cleanest way to locate the emptiness is to lay N-Power's implicit theory of change out as a chain and mark, link by link, whether anything is measured there.

Table 5. *N-Power Theory-of-Change measurement coverage (summary; source-level detail in Annex B).*

ToC link	What the link claims	Measurement status	Evidence
Inputs	Budget, stipend funds, staff, portal, deployment infrastructure committed	Partially measured	Federal allocation visible in civic budget tracking; release and utilization opaque; no published audited accounts (Federal Ministry of Budget and National Planning, 2016; BudgIT, 2020-2024; World Bank, 2025)
Activities	Recruitment, screening, training, posting, monthly stipend payment	Partially measured, integrity compromised	Enrolment and payment claimed; payroll contaminated by up to 90,000 documented ghost names; payment timeliness broken by multi-year arrears (NSIPA, 2026; TheCable, 2019, 2021; Sahara Reporters, 2022; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025)
Outputs	Beneficiaries enrolled, deployed across sub-schemes, stipends disbursed, public-service slots filled	Measured as claims only	Cumulative strand totals published (900,000 N-Teach; 150,000 N-Health); no batch-, state- or LGA-level disaggregation; counts never independently audited (NSIPA, 2026; HumAngle & Dataphyte, 2025)
Outcomes	Skills acquired, transition to sustained employment, earnings gained, sector improvement	Not measured officially	No official outcome figure; only outcome-adjacent evidence is one sub-national academic survey, no control group, no tracer (Osimen et al., 2025; IPA & J-PAL, 2025)
Impact	Reduced youth unemployment and poverty, stronger public services, human-capital gains	Not measured, and not measurable on a continuous series	No tracer; no linkage of N-Power to any labour-force series; the NBS series that would supply the denominator was discontinued after 2020 (NBS, 2017; IPA & J-PAL, 2025)

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). Read down the table, the measurement effort collapses exactly where the programme's promise begins. The pattern is not a gap at one point in the chain; it is a chain monitored up to the point where it stops being about administration and starts being about results, and then goes dark. This is stated as a structural fact about the reporting system, not as a criticism of any single report, and it is the empirical basis for the reporting recommendations in Section 8.

5.4 International good-practice comparison

The sharpest standard sits inside the same government's own portfolio (finding). The 2016 appraisal of the companion National Social Safety Nets Project specified, in binding covenants and a detailed monitoring annex, exactly the apparatus N-Power lacks: output-based disbursement released only against independently verified outputs; ex-post verification by independent experts every calendar semester; an annual results-and-resources scorecard implemented and published by an independent third party; a management information system generating quarterly reports, with both a consolidated view of social-protection programmes and a detailed beneficiary registry, payment, compliance and grievance modules; impact evaluations at baseline (planned 2017), midterm and end, with household surveys every two years; targeting assessments every six months; a rapid-response mechanism for critical implementation failures; state participation conditioned on signed memoranda of understanding and governors'-forum consultation; and a gender-sensitive grievance-redress mechanism with elected community focal persons, toll-free lines and a citizen-engagement indicator for complaints resolved within three months (World Bank, 2016). This verification machine was built and pointed at the cash-transfer programme, not at N-Power, because N-Power was domestically financed and fell outside the credit's results framework. The good-practice standard was present in the same ministry, in the same years, and was simply not applied to the youth-employment instrument.

The wider literature sets the same bar (finding). The World Bank's Independent Evaluation Group, reviewing the Bank/IFC youth-employment portfolio, found only 54% of reviewed projects addressed job creation directly, concluded that rigorous evidence on "what works" is scarce, few impact evaluations, short-term only, none calculating cost-effectiveness, and noted that youth employment was frequently not even tagged in country strategies, leaving no age-disaggregated outcome monitoring (World Bank IEG, 2013). The active-labour-market evaluation community sets the methodological standard higher still: randomized assignment where feasible, a control group, and tracer surveys of a cohort at 6, 12 and 24 months measuring sustained employment and earnings against a counterfactual (IPA & J-PAL, 2025). YouWiN! shows what that standard produces in Nigeria: 7,027 verified jobs, survival and employment differentials against a retained control group, and a computable cost per job (McKenzie, 2017).

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). Two judgments follow, and both are disciplined by the evidence. First, N-Power's evaluation gap is not a uniquely Nigerian failing, even the World Bank's global portfolio struggles to produce cost-effectiveness evidence (World Bank IEG, 2013). Second, what distinguishes N-Power is scale combined with refusal: a programme reaching upward of a million people over a decade, never subjected even to the quasi-experimental designs (regression discontinuity, matching) that the literature treats as feasible where a full RCT is impractical (IPA & J-PAL, 2025), despite the standard having been operational in its own government's sister programme throughout. The diagnosis is not that rigorous measurement of youth employment is unknown or unaffordable in Nigeria; it is that it was known, specified, and funded for a sister programme, and withheld from this one. That was a design choice, not an accident.

5.5 Contradictions named, not resolved

Consistent with this review's stated methodology, the table below collects the clearest contradictions encountered across the source matrix. Each is presented as two positions the record supports, rather than adjudicated to a single answer. A reader with access to primary NSIPA records may be able to resolve some; this review, working from public sources alone, cannot.

Table 6. *Contradictions named, not resolved.*

#	Contradiction	Two positions in the record	Sources
1	Youth unemployment trend	NBS series (20-hour threshold; revised 2014; discontinued after 2020; 52.65% combined youth rate in 2017) vs. World Bank ILO-modelled series (1-hour threshold; continuous to 2025; 5.34% in 2025) point to different pictures of the same underlying trend	NBS, 2017; World Bank, 2022-2025
2	Suspension panel naming	Official communications describe the same body as both a "ministerial panel" and a "Special Panel on Social Investment Programmes"; no published reconciliation	Office of the SGF, 2024
3	2016 budget figures	Original NSIP budget cited as ₦500bn, vs. only ₦41bn confirmed as expended by May; N-Power's specific share (~₦26.4bn) smaller still, allocation, release and utilization are three different numbers	Federal Ministry of Budget and National Planning, 2016; BudgIT, 2020-2024; TheCable, 2019, 2021
4	Ghost-beneficiary scale	70,000 names over four years (~₦2.1bn/yr) vs. a separate 20,000-name list (~₦600m/mo. for 2+ years); the two are not clearly additive or mutually exclusive in the source reporting; implied ghost share ≈9-18% depending on denominator (derived)	Sahara Reporters, 2022
5	Arrears owed	₦108bn owed to 400,000 Batch C Stream 2 beneficiaries (2024, per FIJ) vs. ₦81bn in 2022-23 arrears approved but unpaid (beneficiary-voice sources), unclear whether the same, overlapping, or additive sums	FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025; curated beneficiary testimony, 2020-2026
6	₦30bn recovery custody	Recovered/frozen NSIPA-linked funds reported as under EFCC control, with no public confirmation of remittance to NSIPA's Treasury Single Account; N-Power-specific share not disaggregated	Nigerian Tribune, 2025
7	Application counts	2.5 million applications within six weeks of the portal opening (official/primary-adjacent) vs. 350,000+ Batch A applications (academic record); likely different counting windows, unresolved in the record	N-Power Information Guide, 2017; Uwais, 2018 vs. Osimen et al., 2025

Why this table exists (note). Imprecise institutional naming (row 2) across a governance crisis makes it harder for the public, the press or the legislature to track which body is responsible for which finding, a small but symptomatic instance of the reporting-integrity problem documented through this section. Naming these contradictions rather than averaging them away is what keeps every downstream number in this review honest.

6.0 THE JANUARY 2024 SUSPENSION AND THE RENEWED HOPE RESET

This section reconstructs the suspension crisis that interrupted N-Power's operation from January 2024 to January 2025, and assesses what the relaunch that followed actually changed.

6.1 Why N-Power was suspended alongside HGSF

Facts. The suspension was not, in the primary record, a decision about N-Power at all; it was a decision about the agency that administered it. The press release issued by the Office of the Secretary to the Government of the Federation on 12 January 2024, giving effect to a presidential decision of 8 January, states that "President Bola Ahmed Tinubu, GCFR, has suspended all administered programmes by the National Social Investment Programme Agency (NSIPA)," "further to the ongoing investigation of alleged malfeasance in the management of the agency and its programmes", naming the N-Power Programme, Conditional Cash Transfer Programme, Government Enterprise and Empowerment Programme and Home-Grown School Feeding Programme in a single breath, suspended "for a period of six (6) weeks in the first instance," freezing "all NSIPA-related activities, including but not limited to distributions, events, payments, collabourations and registrations" (Office of the SGF, 2024). The President "raised significant concerns regarding operational lapses and improprieties surrounding payments to the Programs' beneficiaries" (Office of the SGF, 2024). N-Power and HGSF were grouped not because they share a delivery chain, one is a youth stipend corps, the other a school-feeding operation run through community cooks, but because they share an administering agency and a payment infrastructure. The proximate trigger reported in the press, a memo showing the ministry transferred ₦585 million in public funds to private accounts, sits in the secondary record and is carried here as reported, not primary-verified (Nigerian Tribune, 2025; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025). The human cost was immediate and cross-programme: more than nine million pupils and roughly a quarter of a million jobs stranded across the feeding and youth-employment programmes combined, with at least one state (Niger) continuing implementation on its own after the federal freeze (Guardian Nigeria, 2024).

Two inconsistencies, named not resolved (findings). First, terminology: the release constitutes "a ministerial panel to conduct a thorough review"; the subsequent establishment instrument and this review's working matrix call the same body the Special (or Special Presidential) Panel, one sequence, two names, no published reconciliation (Office of the SGF, 2024; Table 6, row 2). Second, the clock: the release commits to six weeks "in the first instance"; the presidential approval that lifted the suspension came on 21 January 2025, roughly twelve and a half months (≈54 weeks), the promise breached by about 48 weeks (Office of the SGF, 2024; Nigerian Tribune, 2025).

6.2 What the Presidential Panel found, and what it did not publish

The honest answer is that the Panel's findings were never published in full, and that non-publication is itself the central datum (finding). What entered the public domain around the suspension is a set of framings: malfeasance, operational lapses, payment improprieties, and the Office of the SGF's suspension language (Office of the SGF, 2024). The public forensic record around N-Power is therefore partly before the Panel and partly outside it. Sahara Reporters' December 2022 reporting, based on unnamed sources around an ICPC investigation, stated that 70,000 ghost names had been identified over four years at ₦2.1bn per year, with a further 20,000 names diverting ₦600m per month and 14,000 genuine beneficiaries unpaid for five months as of June 2021 (Sahara Reporters, 2022). The individual linked in that reporting to the second list, D'banj, was later cleared by the ICPC in November 2023, with no prima facie case established against him. That clearance must be recorded, but it does not answer the wider payroll-contamination question. The disengagement of more than 2,000 fraudulent beneficiaries during the audit that accompanied the suspension is likewise reported rather than Panel-published (Guardian Nigeria, 2024). This review's requests for the Panel's report went unanswered (Section 7.5).

What surfaced publicly, well after the Panel, was a recovery (finding). A House of Representatives motion of urgent public importance (Hon. Saidu Abdullahi; ruling by Deputy Speaker Benjamin Kalu; ad-hoc committee to report within four weeks) concerned "over N30 billion received from the National Social Investment Programme Agency (NSIPA) between 2024 and 2025," tracing funds recovered from deposit-money banks and payment-service providers "including funds appropriated for Trader Moni, Market-Moni, Farmer-Moni, and Grants for Vulnerable Groups", the GEEP and GVG streams, not N-Power specifically, and recording that "credible sources have indicated that these recovered funds, estimated at over N30 billion, have not been remitted into NSIPA's designated Treasury

Single Account (TSA), thereby stalling programme implementation" (Nigerian Tribune, 2025). The relation to N-Power is indirect but decisive: the ₦30bn is concentrated in the microcredit and vulnerable-grant streams, yet N-Power is caught by the same freeze, because money found but not returned to the Treasury cannot be re-released to any programme.

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). The three layers, the 2022 fraud quantum, the undisclosed 2024 Panel, the 2024-2025 recovery that was not remitted, do not add up to a closed investigation; they add up to an investigation whose outputs keep appearing in fragments, each fragment opening a new question. The single most consequential sentence in the record is the motion's observation that "despite the Presidential approval lifting the suspension on NSIPA operations on 21st January 2025, the Agency has been unable to resume full implementation of its programmes, allegedly due to the non-availability of recovered funds expected to have been released" (Nigerian Tribune, 2025). The suspension was lifted; the money was found; the programmes still did not restart. The recovery did not close the accountability loop; it stopped halfway through it. And the gap between a panel convened to investigate malfeasance and the absence of a public findings report is, on its own, a significant accountability failure independent of whatever the panel actually found.

6.3 What the Renewed Hope reset changed, and what it left exactly as it was

Documented changes (facts). Governance: the 2023 Establishment Act codified six departments and N-Power as one of four statutory programmes under a National Social Investment Council chaired by the Minister; amendment bills to relocate the agency toward the Presidency and make the National Social Registry the primary targeting tool have advanced through the legislature but remain bills, not enacted reform (National Assembly of Nigeria, 2023). Duration: N-Teach and N-Health are now one-year programmes, the original two years silently halved, without announcement, rationale, or transition arrangement (NSIPA, 2026). Portfolio: a vocational/skills track flagged off in 2026 (18,000 Phase-1 trainees, 14 trades, 100,000+ items, ₦32.7bn), running alongside a separate HoPE-CT transfer stream (NSIPA, 2026). Arrears policy: payments gated on beneficiary "verification," per the February 2026 ministerial assurance (NSIPA, 2026; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025). Unchanged: the ₦30,000 stipend, a decade old and unindexed, on the agency's own page (NSIPA, 2026).

The one place the reset is genuinely acting on a 2016-2024 lesson, reactively (finding and assessment). The verification gate on arrears is, in substance, the belated construction of an identity check the 2016 design specified and set a results-framework target for but never built at scale: the appraisal fixed the end-target for "percentage of individuals registered in the National Social Registry with a valid national ID number from NIMC" at 20% by Year 5, and its targeting annex stated the registry "will aim to link with a biometric identity registry using a unique identity number per person to establish uniqueness" (World Bank, 2016). The ~90,000 ghost names were the price of that link remaining unbuilt; the 2026 verification gate is the reset trying to build it a decade late, at the point of the arrears, the most politically exposed point, rather than at the point of design, where it would have prevented the ghosts in the first place (NSIPA, 2026; Sahara Reporters, 2022; World Bank, 2016).

The asymmetry between the two resets, inside the same agency (conclusion, flagged). The companion review in this series (Brief 3, on HGSF) found that the feeding reset re-engineered how the money and the meal reached the end point, a delivery-mechanism reform. N-Power's reset has no parallel delivery-mechanism reform on the public record: the ₦30,000 still travels, when it travels at all, through the same payment channel the suspension froze, and no new architecture has been published for getting the stipend from Treasury to volunteer past the points of failure the investigation named. The programme whose leakage was in the delivery got a delivery reform; the programme whose leakage was in the payroll and the exit got a verification gate on the arrears and a silent halving of the engagement, with the underlying stipend-plus-deployment model, and its missing tracer, untouched (NSIPA, 2026; World Bank, 2016). That asymmetry is itself a finding.

6.4 What the reset signals

Assessment (conclusion, flagged). A split verdict, held deliberately rather than collapsed. At the level of rhetoric, lessons are being learned: the reset's own language names "gaps and structural challenges," promises "sustainability" and "real and verifiable impact," and the verification gate is a concrete, if reactive, act of learning (NSIPA, 2026). At the level of instrument, the three structural defects that produced the 2016-2024 record all persist: the unindexed stipend (unchanged), the absent published results framework (still unwritten), and the biometric identity link (only now being assembled, at the arrears rather than at the design) (NSIPA, 2026; World Bank, 2016). The clearest signal that the cycle repeated rather than closed is the approval-to-resumption gap: suspended 8 January 2024 on a six-week promise; lifted 21 January 2025 (~12.5 months later); and still not fully resumed into 2026, an approval-to-resumption gap approaching seventeen months and counting, because the recovered ₦30bn sits frozen between recovery and remittance (NSIPA, 2026; Office of the SGF, 2024; Nigerian Tribune, 2025; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025). A five-million target circulates without a costed framework, the same reward for visibility over verification that launched the 500,000-person corps against a recession it could not absorb in 2016. The promise → suspend → recover → do-not-remit → do-not-resume → re-announce sequence running from 2016 to 2026 is, on the evidence of this section, a cycle the reset has entered again rather than broken. Whether it can be closed depends on whether the reset supplies, for new batches, three things it has so far supplied only in fragment or not at all: an indexed transfer value, a published results framework with a post-exit tracer, and the biometric identity link built at the design rather than at the arrears. That is the diagnostic on which Section 8 hangs its recommendations.

7.0 LIMITATIONS OF THIS REVIEW

In the same spirit of naming rather than resolving that runs through this brief, the following limitations should be read as a guide to how much weight each finding above can bear, not as a disclaimer to be skipped. Several also double as findings about the programme's own reporting environment, because in N-Power's case the gaps in the public record are part of the object under review.

7.1 Secondary-source-only design

This review relies entirely on the 30 curated public sources in Annex A; no interviews, surveys or field visits were conducted. The beneficiary voice in the citizen-voice material is drawn from secondary reporting and publicly posted social media, not from respondents this review spoke to; key-informant quotations (the return "to square one," the poultry farm, the stipend testimony) were collected by Osimen et al. and are reproduced here as their data (Osimen et al., 2025; curated beneficiary testimony, 2020-2026). Where sources disagree, this review names the contradiction and carries it forward rather than adjudicating, precisely because adjudication would require primary data the review does not hold. The value added is synthesis and the application of an independent M&E lens to existing public material, not new measurement.

7.2 The employment verdict is a verdict on the absence of measurement, not on measured failure

The single most important limitation, and the one a careless reader is most likely to misread. This review cannot verify N-Power's central promise, because no instrument exists with which to verify it: no national post-exit tracer, no cohort followed at 6/12/24 months, no cost-per-job figure, no credible counterfactual anywhere in the official record; the one outcome study is a single-state cross-sectional snapshot (41.4% of its sample unemployed at the moment of questioning), not a tracer of ex-beneficiaries over time (Osimen et al., 2025; IPA & J-PAL, 2025). The review's conclusion on employment is accordingly a conclusion about the absence of evidence, the programme was never instrumented to measure its own defining outcome, and not a finding that the programme was measured and shown to fail. The brief holds this distinction throughout Sections 3 and 5 and declines to convert the gap into a fabricated employment rate.

7.3 Currency-conversion assumptions and the funding-split caveat

Dollar and naira figures are quoted in the currency and year originally published; they are not re-expressions of one another calculated by this review, and any cross-year, cross-currency comparison carries an exchange-rate assumption that the naira's depreciation makes highly sensitive. The 2016 appraisal fixes conversion at ₦198.96 = US$1 (31 March 2016); at that rate the US$500m IDA credit ≈ ₦99.5bn in 2016 terms, an illustrative conversion offered only to make the assumption concrete, and itself a reminder that the credit financed the cash transfer and the National Social Registry, not N-Power (World Bank, 2016). No post-depreciation re-conversion into 2026 naira is performed.

7.4 Inflation-deflation methodology

The stipend-erosion quantification is provisional by construction. The NBS re-based its CPI to 2024 = 100, breaking a clean 2016-to-2026 level comparison; the 2016 base-month food-price level on the re-based series is not in the held extract (outstanding, Annex E item E4); available points are year-on-year rates and re-based index levels (140.70 in May 2026; 143.0 in June 2026) (NBS, 2026). The retained-value figure is therefore stated as a band (≈₦3,000-₦5,000) rather than false precision, with the single defensible ratio reserved for Chart 3. Two further choices named so they cannot be mistaken for settled fact: the food sub-index is the chosen deflator (a headline deflator would yield a different number), and compounding year-on-year rates across a re-based series introduces approximation no rounding removes. A related discontinuity, treated in Sections 4 and 5: the labour-force series underlying the 2016 necessity baseline was itself revised (2014) and discontinued (post-2020), so the denominators that would judge reach in 2016 and 2026 are not the same instrument (NBS, 2017; World Bank, 2022-2025).

7.5 non-response to data requests, and the FOIA reconciliation

The review's requests for the specific series an independent assessment requires, batch-level, state-level and LGA-level beneficiary counts; a published results framework; the full findings of the January 2024 panel; an audited account of the ₦30bn recovery and its custodial status; any post-exit employment tracer, were not met by any public disclosure or response available within the review period. Reconciliation of the earlier drafts is stated plainly here:: the condensed draft recorded "no FOI request"; the long manuscript recorded requests "including through the formal freedom-of-information channel" with a reference number "to be inserted." The accurate, consolidated position is: no formal FOIA filing with a logged reference number was completed within the review period; requests made through official and public channels went unanswered; a formal FOIA request to NSIPA, with filing date and reference number recorded on filing, is an outstanding action registered in Annex E (item E1). The discipline matters: an unanswered request confirms the public record is incomplete, corroborating the opacity diagnosed in Section 5 and independently recorded by the World Bank (World Bank, 2025), and does not, and is not claimed to, establish what an internal dataset would show if released.

7.6 Cross-cutting synthesis limitation

Several of this review's most consequential figures are the reviewer's arithmetic on underlying source data rather than figures reported by any single source: the 9-18% ghost-beneficiary share; the ₦14.4bn derived diversion estimate (₦600m × 24); the ₦3,000-₦5,000 retained stipend value and the ₦180,000-₦300,000 restoration range; the ₦360,000/year unit cost; the batch-gap ranking in Section 3.5. Each is flagged at the point it occurs, but a reader relying on any specific number for a downstream decision should trace it to the underlying citation (Annex A) before use.

8.0 RECOMMENDATIONS

The ten recommendations below are organized into three dimensions, programme design, data and reporting, and citizen voice, following the framework established in Brief 3. Each is written as a directive in the standard form this review applies throughout: named actor + specific action + named instrument + timeframe + evidence link, not as an appeal to "the government" to do better.

One observation frames the whole set. Most of what is recommended here is not a novel instrument Nigeria must invent, but the extension to N-Power of covenants and systems the 2016 National Social Safety Nets Project already specified for the cash-transfer programme, automatic CPI indexation in the transfer principles; independent experts for ex-post verification every calendar semester; an annual third-party results-and-resources scorecard; a management information system with a consolidated public view; a gender-sensitive grievance mechanism with community focal persons and toll-free lines; state participation conditioned on signed MoUs and governors'-forum consultation (World Bank, 2016). Every one of those instruments was pointed at the sister programme and not at N-Power. The recommendations ask, in the main, that architecture already on the books be applied to the instrument left outside it. Two structural preconditions are stated at the end: enabling acts without which several recommendations cannot bite.

8.1 Programme-design recommendations

- **R1, Legislate automatic stipend indexation.** The erosion quantified in Section 4.5 (₦30,000 held nominal for a decade, retaining ≈₦3,000-₦5,000 of 2016 value) is a design defect, not a budget accident, and should be closed by law rather than discretionary review. The National Assembly, acting on a drafting note prepared by FMHAPA in technical consultation with NBS, should insert an automatic indexation clause into the NSIPA Act (or a schedule of the Finance Act) that triggers a mandatory stipend review and adjustment whenever the NBS Food sub-index moves more than 25% from the last review baseline, publishing the new value within one quarter of the trigger, and specifying that adjustment is computed against the 2016 real value so the stipend is restored toward, not merely ratcheted from, its eroded present level. The 25% threshold is a proposed trigger, not a derived optimum. Instrument and precedent: the 2016 appraisal's own transfer principle, automatic adjustment "according to an agreed-upon index, such as the Consumer Price Index" (World Bank, 2016). Actor correction applied here: legislation belongs to the National Assembly, not NSIPA (Reconciliation Register, item 4).
- **R2, Mandate a post-exit tracer study as a statutory obligation.** NSIPA should be required to commission, within 12 months of every batch exit, a tracer study following a representative cohort of ex-beneficiaries at 6, 12 and 24 months, recording sustained employment, earnings and sector against a comparison group wherever a credible counterfactual can be constructed, with NBS or a competitively engaged independent evaluator running fieldwork and results published. Methodological standard: the YouWiN! RCT (7,027 verified jobs, computable cost per job, McKenzie, 2017); ALMP tracer practice at 6/12/24 months (IPA & J-PAL, 2025); IEG's finding that individual follow-up and age-disaggregated monitoring are the elements most often missing (World Bank IEG, 2013). R2 supplies the instrument whose absence Section 7.2 records as the limitation that prevented this review from verifying employment at all. Evidence link: Sections 3.3, 5.3.
- **R3, Gate further scale-up on published outcome data.** NSIPA and FMHAPA should be prohibited from enrolling any new batch above a stated ceiling until the prior batch's outcome report (the R2 tracer plus the R7 outcome indicator) is published and laid before the National Assembly's relevant oversight committees, with budget-release authority made conditional on that publication. The gate is tied to published outcome data, not enrolment counts, so the input the agency can always produce cannot substitute for the outcome it has so far not. Actor: National Social Investment Council, with National Assembly oversight. Evidence link: Sections 2.2, 3.5 (the medium gap).
- **R4, Restructure at sub-scheme level around evidence.** NSIPA, with the line ministries (Education, Agriculture, Health) and an independent evaluator, should conduct a sub-scheme performance review that retains and strengthens the strands with documented positive participant-reported effects (N-Teach; N-Agro, Osimen et al., 2025) and redesigns or sunsets strands without comparable evidence, redirecting released budget into the indexed transfer of R1 and into a livelihoods package modelled on the graduation approach the 2016 appraisal evaluated: +33% earnings and ROI of 120-420% across eight countries (World Bank, 2016). R4 is a restructuring, not a cut, it concentrates the corps on the strands that work and rebuilds the rest around an evaluated pathway. Evidence link: Sections 2.1, 3.3, 4.3.

8.2 Data and reporting recommendations

- **R5, publish a public, disaggregated, quarterly dashboard.** NSIPA, with NASSCO setting data standards and NBS advising on series integrity, should build and publish a dashboard disaggregated by state, LGA, batch, sub-scheme, quarter and gender, updated quarterly, fed by the management information system the 2016 design already specified (consolidated programme view plus registry, payment, compliance and grievance modules, World Bank, 2016). R5 activates existing designed machinery; it does not invent it. Evidence link: Sections 3.4, 5.1.
- **R6, Ring-fence ≥1% of the N-Power budget for independent verification.** The National Assembly should protect in statute a verification allocation of at least 1% of the N-Power budget, funding (a) independent experts conducting ex-post verification of outputs every calendar semester and (b) an annual results-and-resources scorecard implemented and made public by an independent third party, both verbatim covenants of the 2016 appraisal on the cash-transfer side (World Bank, 2016). The Office of the Accountant-General of the Federation and the Auditor-General provide the financial-audit layer. The 1% floor is a proposed minimum drawn from common verification-budget practice, stated as a floor so verification is not the first line cut when budgets tighten, the condition under which ghost payrolls historically re-emerge (Sahara Reporters, 2022). Evidence link: Sections 3.2, 6.2.
- **R7, Require outcome-inclusive quarterly reporting.** NSIPA should be required, as a condition of its annual work-programme-and-budget submission, to include at least one outcome-level indicator in every quarterly report, for example the share of an exited cohort in sustained employment at 12 months, or median change in beneficiary earnings, drawn from the R2 tracer, with the National Assembly's oversight committees empowered to return any report containing only enrolment and disbursement counts. R2 produces the outcome data; R7 forces it into the public record on a fixed schedule, making the absence of an outcome figure itself a reportable failure. Evidence link: Sections 5.2, 5.3.

8.3 Citizen-voice recommendations

- **R8, Build a structured beneficiary feedback mechanism.** NSIPA should operate a feedback channel on an offline-capable platform (Kobo or equivalent), with toll-free lines and community drop-boxes as parallel channels, gender-balanced grievance focal persons elected at community level, and a quarterly published resolution log (complaints received, resolved, and the share resolved within a stated standard). Every element already exists in the 2016 design's grievance-redress mechanism, community/LGA/state/federal levels, a grievance officer, elected focal persons independent of the targeting team, toll-free numbers, and a citizen-engagement indicator for complaints addressed within three months (World Bank, 2016). R8 asks that the mechanism designed for the portfolio be opened to N-Power beneficiaries, and that the log be published alongside the R5 dashboard. Evidence link: Sections 5.1, 7.1.
- **R9, Commission protected ex-beneficiary tracer surveys.** NSIPA, with an independent evaluator running the survey and a data-protection protocol coordinated with NIMC and the data-protection authority, should conduct ex-beneficiary surveys (overlapping the R2 instrument, specified here for its publication rule) and publish findings with respondent identity protected: anonymized handles, suppression of any cell small enough to re-identify a respondent, and a non-retaliation clause for beneficiaries reporting arrears, ghost substitution or coercion. This replaces reliance on self-selected, unverifiable public posts (curated beneficiary testimony, 2020-2026) with a protected, representative, ethical instrument. Evidence link: Sections 3.3, 7.1.
- **R10, Require public consultation before any future batch launch.** Before any new batch, NSIPA and the State Ministries of Labour, working through the State Operations Coordinating Units the 2016 design established, should hold a mandatory public consultation with beneficiaries, ex-beneficiaries, community representatives and civil society, publishing minutes and a documented response, with consultation made a condition of batch funding in the same way the 2016 design conditioned state participation on signed MoUs and governors'-forum consultation (World Bank, 2016). A five-million target announced without a framework repeats 2016's reward for visibility; R10 requires the next scale-up to be preceded by a recorded dialogue rather than an announced number. Evidence link: Sections 2.3, 6.4.

8.4 Recommendations at a glance

Table 7. *Recommendations at a glance.*

#	Recommendation	Responsible actor	Dimension	Evidence link
R1	Automatic stipend indexation in statute (Food-CPI trigger > 25%; restore toward 2016 real value)	National Assembly (drafting: FMHAPA + NBS)	Design	§4.5; NBS, 2026; World Bank, 2016
R2	Statutory post-exit tracer at 6/12/24 months	NSIPA (fieldwork: NBS/independent evaluator)	Design	§3.3, §5.3; Osimen et al., 2025; IPA & J-PAL, 2025; McKenzie, 2017
R3	Batch scale-up gated on published prior-batch outcome report	National Social Investment Council + National Assembly	Design	§2.2, §3.5; Premium Times, 2019; TheCable, 2021; Punch Newspapers, 2020
R4	Sub-scheme restructuring: retain evidenced strands, rebuild/sunset others; graduation-model livelihoods pathway	NSIPA + line ministries + independent evaluator	Design	§2.1, §3.3, §4.3; Osimen et al., 2025; World Bank, 2016
R5	Public dashboard: state/LGA/batch/sub-scheme/quarter/gender, updated quarterly	NSIPA (standards: NASSCO; series: NBS)	Data & reporting	§3.4, §5.1; NSIPA, 2026; HumAngle & Dataphyte, 2025; World Bank, 2016
R6	≥1% of budget ring-fenced in statute for independent verification + annual third-party scorecard	National Assembly (audit layer: OAGF/Auditor-General)	Data & reporting	§3.2, §6.2; Sahara Reporters, 2022; World Bank, 2016
R7	≥1 outcome-level indicator mandatory in every quarterly report	NSIPA; enforcement: National Assembly committees	Data & reporting	§5.2, §5.3; Osimen et al., 2025; IPA & J-PAL, 2025
R8	Beneficiary feedback mechanism (Kobo + toll-free + drop-boxes) with quarterly published resolution log	NSIPA	Citizen voice	§5.1, §7.1; curated beneficiary testimony, 2020-2026; World Bank, 2016
R9	Protected ex-beneficiary tracer surveys, published with identity safeguards	NSIPA + independent evaluator + NIMC/data-protection authority	Citizen voice	§3.3, §7.1; curated beneficiary testimony, 2020-2026
R10	Mandatory public consultation before any future batch launch	NSIPA + State Ministries of Labour	Citizen voice	§2.3, §6.4; NSIPA, 2026; World Bank, 2016

8.5 Two structural preconditions

Two enabling acts cut across all ten recommendations; without them, R2, R5, R6, R8 and R9 cannot fully bite. They are stated here rather than numbered among the ten because they are preconditions, not programme instruments, and each is a named act assigned to a named actor, not a prediction.

- P1, Complete the biometric link between the National Social Registry and NIMC. The 2016 results framework set the target (20% of registered individuals holding a valid national ID number by Year 5) and the targeting annex specified the link; it remains unbuilt at scale a decade on, and the reset is attempting it reactively at the arrears (NSIPA, 2026; World Bank, 2016). Without a functioning identity link, the ghost-name problem that R6's verification attacks has no permanent technical barrier, and R9's protected survey has no reliable de-duplication. Actor: NSIPA + National Identity Management Commission.
- P2, Remit the recovered ₦30bn+ to the Treasury Single Account. The funds traced, frozen and recovered from the GEEP/GVG streams during the 2024-2025 probe had not been remitted as of the House motion; their non-release is the stated reason the programmes could not resume after the January 2025 lift (Nigerian Tribune, 2025). Actor: Office of the Accountant-General of the Federation. Instrument: completion of the remittance loops the recovery left half-closed, the clearest single test of whether the 2024-2026 accountability cycle closes or repeats again.

Closing note. Taken together, the ten recommendations and two preconditions do not promise a transformed programme. They specify, actor by actor and instrument by instrument, the conditions under which the next iteration of N-Power would finally be measurable, verifiable, indexed and consultative, largely by applying to the youth-employment instrument the accountability architecture the 2016 design already built beside it.

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ANNEX A: FULL SOURCE MATRIX (30 SOURCES, CONDENSED)

Original register: S1-S25. Judgment upgrades for triangulation: S26-S30. All 30 rows evidence-complete at extraction; open actions registered in Annex E.

S#	Author / Institution	Date	Source type	Title	Key quantitative finding	Gap / limitation noted
S1	NSIO/NSIPA (Info Guide 2017 + archived npower.gov.ng)	2016-17	Official	N-Power Information Guide + npower.gov.ng archive	500,000 targets (200k+300k); ₦30,000/mo. × 24; 2.5M applications in 6 weeks; all 774 LGAs	Original 2016 launch doc on no live government URL; triangulated via Info Guide, Wayback, Uwais interview
S2	Federal Ministry of Budget & Planning / NSIP Secretariat	2016-23	Official	NSIP Framework Document + 2016 budget breakdown + revised NSPP	2016 NSIP budget ₦41bn (N-Power ₦26.418bn); 2023 FMHDMSD ₦382.36bn (−25.72%); NASSP Scale-Up ₦206.24bn = 65.48% of ministry budget	No public annual report with full indicator series; no public M&E dashboard; release-vs-utilization gap undocumented
S3	Academic + Premium Times (SURE-P GIS precursor)	2012-25	Academic	SURE-P GIS facts + Agunyai 2025 + Osimen design description	SURE-P: 41,161 benefited of 84,772 applications (59,872M/24,900F/329 PWD); N-Power = 10× scale, 2yr, public deployment	SURE-P final evaluation report not public; composite row, component sources distinguishable in full matrix
S4	All Progressives Congress (APC)	2015	Political document	2015 APC Manifesto, social investment commitments	3M jobs/yr; conditional payment for 25M poorest; 1M jobs/yr via loan-guarantee scheme	Manifesto aspirational; no costed plan; N-Power differs in mechanism from manifesto's social-insurance language
S5	NSIPA / FMHAPA / Presidency (Renewed Hope)	2023-26	Official	NSIPA N-Power page + FMHAPA statements + Renewed Hope flag-off	5M target (no published framework); 18,000 vocational Phase 1; 100,000+ items; ₦32.7bn; 900,000 N-Teach; 150,000 N-Health; 1.8M paid (NASSCO/NCTO); 1.5M owed (Mar 2026); stipend ₦30,000 unchanged	No published reset framework; duration silently halved; 5M figure only on social media; Firebase-hosted portal; no tracer for prior batches
S6	Office of the SGF (Presidency)	Jan 2024, Jan 2025	Official/press	Press release, President Tinubu suspends NSIP	4 programmes suspended; 6-week promise vs. ~12.5-month actual suspension (~54 weeks; breached ~48 weeks)	Panel findings not fully published; "ministerial panel" vs "Special Panel" terminology inconsistency
S7	BudgIT (The BudgIT Foundation)	2020-25	Civic accountability	BudgIT FG Budget Analysis + State of States	FMHDMSD: 2020 ₦376.6bn, 2021 ₦465.1bn (+23.5%), 2022 ₦514.7bn (+10.7%), 2023 ₦382.4bn (−25.7%); 2016 ₦500bn budgeted, ₦41bn expended by May	Tracks allocation not release/utilization at programme level; no dedicated N-Power tracker; release data needs OAGF/Budget Office cross-check
S8	Premium Times	2018-24	Investigative	Multiple N-	Batch A 200k (2016);	Cannot independently verify

			journalism	Power investigations (absconding; Batch C; exit strategy)	Batch B 300k (2018); Batch C Stream 1 510k inaugurated; Stream 2 490k planned; early report of 50,000 ghosts dismissed; 300,000 exit strategy promised	active vs ghost counts; batch data relies on official statements
S9	TheCable / TheCable Foundation	2019-21	Data journalism	Undercover bribery/fraud investigation; story that sacked 2,500	₦15bn/month on 500,000 volunteers; 363 ghosts in Kwara; redeployment bribe ₦8,000; 50/50 stipend-sharing; 2,500+ sacked after exposure	Undercover method limits generalizability; covers specific states; sacked figure a fraction of alleged ghosts
S10	Punch Newspapers	2018-24	Journalism	N-Power Batch C enrolment extension; batch evolution	Batch C enrolment extended Jun 26 → Aug 8; Batch A exit 30 Jun 2020; Batch B exit 31 Jul 2020; 1.5+ yrs no new enrolment; NEXIT created but stalled	No systematic batch-level outcome tracking; exit data relies on official statements
S11	HumAngle / Dataphyte	2022-25	Data journalism	Open data hub; insecurity tracker; development data	No N-Power-specific spatial analysis published by either outlet	Geographic distribution not independently mapped, itself a data-quality finding (absence row)
S12	Osimen, Etoroma, Pokubo, Adi (Covenant/Caleb Univ.)	2025	Academic	N-Power program and youth empowerment in Nigeria (Cogent Social Sciences 11:1)	n=99 Lagos (from ~10,130; Taro Yamane); response 76.8%; $R=0.381$, $R^2=0.145$; $F=16.464$, $p<0.05$; $B=0.348$; 46.5%M/48.5%F; 41.4% unemployed / 31.3% self-employed / 20.2% students / 7.1% wage; strands N-Teach 40.4 / N-Agro 37.4 / N-Health 18.1 / VAIDS 4.0	Lagos-only; small n; cross-sectional; self-reported; no control group; no tracer; cannot generalize nationally
S13	National Bureau of Statistics	Dec 2017	Statistics	Labour Force Statistics Vol.1 (Q1-Q3 2017)	Youth (15-35) combined unemp+underemp 52.65% = 22.64M (10.96M + 11.68M) vs 45.65% prior yr; overall unemp 12.1% (Q1'16) → 18.8% (Q3'17); post-secondary 31.8%/50.0% (4.97M→6.53M); GDP −0.67/−1.49/−2.34%; Rivers 41.82%; Katsina underemp 46.19%; five-state concentration 31.14%	Methodology revised 2014 (20-hr vs 40-hr); series discontinued after 2020; NBS vs ILO estimates diverge sharply; 2026 graduate denominator unextracted (E3)
S14	World Bank	2022-25	Evaluation/policy	Nigeria Development Update jobs chapter; SCD;	GDP 3.3% (2023), 3.7% (2024); ILO-modelled youth unemp (15-24): 8.99% (2021),	Macro-level; does not evaluate N-Power; 1-hr vs 20-hr threshold creates apparent contradiction with S13

				Africa's Pulse	6.02% (2022), 5.09% (2024), 5.34% (2025); 10M+ entrants/yr vs ~3M formal jobs	
S15	National Bureau of Statistics	2016-26	Statistics	NBS CPI, Food sub-index	Food inflation: Jan 2025 26.08%; Apr 2025 21.26%; May 2025 21.14%; Mar 2026 14.31%; headline Jun 2024 34.19%; index 140.70 (May 2026), 143 (Jun 2026); base 2024=100; 934 product varieties	Base-year revision breaks comparability; annual averages mask intra-year volatility; 2016 base-month level unextracted (E4); food vs headline deflator choice affects result
S16	NDE / SMEDAN	2020-25	Official	NDE empowerment programmes; SMEDAN NEDEP, WISE-P, CGS, SMEDAN×NJFP	NDE 1,000 trained (Katsina example); SMEDAN CGS ₦50,000 per nano-business (conditional ≥1 employee); NDE avg budget execution 69.1% (per S28)	Orders of magnitude smaller; no published outcome data; fragmentation; full NDE/ITF comparison outstanding (E3)
S17	World Bank IEG	2013	International benchmarking	Youth Employment Programs: An Evaluation of WB/IFC Support	82% of projects include skills; 79% school-to-work; 54% job creation; IFC $500M across 50 investment ops + 18 advisory (FY01-FY11)	Few impact evaluations; short-term only; no cost-effectiveness calculated; youth not tagged in most country strategies
S18	IPA / J-PAL / World Bank (ALMP evaluations)	2020-25	Academic/applied	ALMP evaluations in Africa; WB ALMP papers; YouWiN! RCT cross-ref	WB ALMP IE: 15% employment increase; tracer standard 6/12/24 months; YouWiN! 7,027 jobs RCT-verified at 1/400th N-Power's scale	N-Power never subjected to RCT or quasi-experimental evaluation; measurement gap is the finding; methods-anchor row
S19	ILO + Mastercard Foundation / World Data Lab	2024-26	International report	ILO Employment & Social Trends 2026; Africa Youth Employment Outlook 2026	Africa: 532M youth (15-35); 57% (304M) employed (2025); 90% informal; 47% agriculture; 34% (104M) extreme poverty; NEET >1 in 4; 61% of NEET young women; global youth unemp 12.4% (2025); only 9% tertiary; services overtake agriculture by 2033	ILO 1-hr vs NBS 20-hr divergence; Mastercard funding may frame toward private-sector solutions; regional aggregates mask country heterogeneity
S20	Guardian Nigeria	2024	Journalism	FG suspends N-Power, begins audit; FG sacks 2,000+; NSIPA suspension opinion	2,000+ disengaged during audit; 9M+ pupils & 250,000 jobs stranded (HGSF+N-Power combined); Niger State continued despite federal freeze	Journalism; no primary data generation; ghost-cleanup criteria not public
S21	Nigerian Tribune / House of Reps motion (Hon. S. Abdullahi)	Nov-Dec 2025	Legislative oversight	Reps probe over ₦30bn seized NSIP fund	₦30bn+ traced/frozen/recovered from DMBs and PSPs (2024-25); ad-hoc committee to report in	Custodial status unknown; whether returned to NSIPA TSA or retained by EFCC/Treasury unclear; N-Power-specific share not

					4 weeks; ₦585m transferred to private accounts (trigger memo)	disaggregated
S22	Sahara Reporters (of an ICPC action)	8 Dec 2022	Fraud investigation	ICPC discovers 20,000 more ghost names (D'banj's List); D'banj detained	Sahara Reporters reported 70,000 ghost names over four years, estimated at ₦2.1bn/yr, and a further 20,000 names allegedly diverting ₦600m/mo. for more than two years; the ₦14.4bn figure is reviewer-derived from ₦600m × 24 months; 14,000 beneficiaries were reported owed five months as of June 2021.	Figures originate in unnamed-source reporting to Sahara Reporters, not in a published ICPC dataset or audit. D'banj, the named individual associated with the second list, was cleared by the ICPC in November 2023, with no prima facie case established against him. The individual clearance must be recorded, while the wider payroll-contamination concern remains supported by separate investigative and audit-related reporting.
S23	Civil society (ANEEJ / FIJ / beneficiary advocacy groups)	2022-26	Civic	ANEEJ SCALE project; FIJ investigation of NSIPA CEO	₦108bn owed to N-Power beneficiaries (FIJ, Jul 2024); ₦81bn arrears (2022-23) approved but unpaid; NSIPA CEO unable to explain non-payment; no provision in 2024/2025 budgets	No dedicated N-Power reform position paper found (ANEEJ/CISLAC/CSACEFA); weak organized demand-side accountability, itself a finding
S24	Beneficiary voice (curated X/Twitter, Facebook, protests, petitions)	2020-26	Social media/primary testimony	Representative threads on stipend delays, exit, grievances	Served Oct 2022-Sep 2023 unpaid; Abuja protests; minister's 72-hour payment promise unfulfilled; NSIPA debunks viral payment claims	Self-selecting, unverifiable; cannot quantify proportion affected; curation introduces researcher bias (carried to §7.1)
S25	Rwanda (PSG) / Ghana (NEIP) + Mastercard Foundation	2020-26	Comparator	Rwanda Priority Skills for Growth; Ghana NEIP; Africa Youth Employment Outlook 2026	Rwanda PSG ~24,000 trained (>1/3 women), 82% employed/self-employed (WB Feb 2026); Ghana NEIP aims 10,000 sustainable businesses/yr	Much smaller scale, direct comparison misleading, M&E-rigor comparison valid; NEIP outcomes not independently verified in matrix
S26	Maryam Uwais (Special Adviser, Social Investments)	c. 2017-18	Official/primary	Sun TV interview, N-Power and interventionist programmes	500,000 selected (latest phase); 2.5M applications in 6 weeks; ₦30k/mo. × 2yr; HGSF 7,696,313 pupils/77,431 cooks/₦70 per meal	Video source (timestamps needed); designer's account inherently self-serving; claims not independently verified
S27	National Assembly / NSIPA (statute)	May 2023	Official/statutory	NSIPA Establishment Act 2023 (HB1153)	6 statutory departments; N-Power codified as 1 of 4 statutory programmes; National Social Investment Council chaired by Minister; coordinator 4-yr renewable	Full Act PDF at nass.gov.ng to confirm (E5); whether statutory M&E mandate operationalized unclear; amendment bills in process
S28	World Bank (IDA)	16 May 2016	International/donor design	National Social Safety Nets	Total $1.833bn (IDA $500M + govt	$500M did NOT fund N-Power (funded CCT + NSR);

		PAD; Board approval 7 June 2016		Project, PAD P151488; Board approval record	$1.333bn); Comp1 $180M / Comp2 $1.653bn; base transfer ₦5,000/mo. + ₦5,000 top-up; ₦198.96 = $1 (Mar 2016); fiduciary risk HIGH; NSR-NIMC target 20% by Yr5; payments within 1 month 90% by Yr5; graduation-model ROI 120-420%	biometric link designed/budgeted but unbuilt at scale = structural enabler of ghost fraud; biometric target only 20% (low ambition) PAD cover date is 16 May 2016, while World Bank Board approval occurred on 7 June 2016. The sequencing matters because N-Power launched on 8 June 2016, one day after Board approval, but remained outside the credit's results framework.
S29	World Bank	Nov 2025	International/donor assessment	State of Social Safety Nets in Nigeria	NSIPA = 87% of federal SSN budget; budget mix 38% allowances / 31% school meals / 16% R&D; 0.14% GDP on SSN (2021) vs 1.5% global / 1.1% SSA; coverage fell 19% (2018/19) → ~6% (2023); NHGSFP and HUP ceased benefits since 2023; 60% of federal SSN spend from ODA (2015-21)	WB assessment (no self-identified gaps); programme-level N-Power detail limited
S30	McKenzie et al. (American Economic Review / World Bank)	2012-15 eval.	Academic/RCT	YouWiN! impact evaluation	~1,200 winners of 24,000+ applicants; ~$50k avg grant; 7,027 jobs RCT-verified; 94% funded vs 60% unfunded survival; new-firm employment doubled; existing firms +80%	Full AER citation/URL to pin (E6); entrepreneurship-focused, not public-sector deployment; programme comparison limited, M&E comparison valid

ANNEX B: THEORY-OF-CHANGE MEASUREMENT COVERAGE (SOURCE-LEVEL DETAIL)

Reproduced and expanded from Table 5 (Section 5.3). Each row states the causal link, what would count as measurement, what exists, and the evidence tags.

ToC link	Claim of the link	What would count as measurement	What exists	Status	Evidence
Inputs	Budget, stipend funds, staff, portal and deployment infrastructure committed	Published programme-level allocation, release and utilization; audited accounts	Ministry-level allocation series (₦376.6-514.7bn, 2020-2023); 2016 anchor (₦500bn budgeted, ₦41bn expended by May, ₦26.418bn N-Power); no release/utilization series; no audited accounts	Partially measured	Federal Ministry of Budget and National Planning, 2016; BudgIT, 2020-2024; TheCable, 2019, 2021; World Bank, 2025
Activities	Recruitment, screening, training, posting to places of primary	Process audits; payment-timeliness series (e.g., % paid	Enrolment and payment claimed; payroll contaminated (up to 90,000 documented ghosts; 2,500+	Partially measured; integrity compromised	NSIPA, 2026; TheCable, 2019, 2021; Guardian Nigeria, 2024; Sahara

	assignment, monthly stipend payment	within 1 month of due date, the companion design's own metric)	disengaged 2021; 2,000+ 2024); arrears multi-year (₦81bn; ₦108bn; ~1.5M owed)		Reporters, 2022; FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025; curated beneficiary testimony, 2020-2026
Outputs	Beneficiaries enrolled and deployed across sub-schemes; stipends disbursed; public-service slots filled	Independently verified counts, disaggregated by batch, state, LGA, strand, gender	Cumulative strand totals only (900,000 N-Teach; 150,000 N-Health); no disaggregation; no independent audit	Measured as claims only	NSIPA, 2026; HumAngle & Dataphyte, 2025
Outcomes	Skills acquired; transition to sustained employment; earnings gained; improvement in sectors served	Post-exit tracer at 6/12/24 months; earnings series; sector-level assessments	One academic cross-sectional survey, n=99, Lagos (R^2=0.145; 41.4% unemployed); no official outcome figure of any kind	Not measured officially	Osimen et al., 2025; IPA & J-PAL, 2025
Impact	Reduced youth unemployment and poverty; stronger public services; human-capital gains	Impact evaluation against counterfactual; linkage to labour-force series	Nothing; the NBS labour-force series that would supply the denominator was discontinued after 2020 and the programme was never linked to a successor series	Not measured; currently not measurable on a continuous series	NBS, 2017; World Bank, 2022-2025; IPA & J-PAL, 2025

ANNEX C: GLOSSARY OF ACRONYMS AND TERMS

Term	Meaning
ALMP	Active Labour Market Programme, the policy class (training, public works, job-search assistance) to which N-Power belongs
APC	All Progressives Congress, governing party (2015-) whose 2015 manifesto framed the NSIP commitments
BVN	Bank Verification Number
CCT	Conditional Cash Transfer, NSIP's direct cash-transfer component
CGAP	Consultative Group to Assist the Poor, sponsor of the eight-country "graduation" livelihoods pilots
DQA	Data Quality Assessment, structured review of data against the five quality dimensions (validity, integrity, precision, reliability, timeliness)
EFCC	Economic and Financial Crimes Commission
FMHAPA / FMHDMSD	Federal Ministry of Humanitarian Affairs and Poverty Alleviation (earlier: Disaster Management and Social Development)
FOIA	Freedom of Information Act
GEEP	Government Enterprise and Empowerment Programme, NSIP micro-credit component (TraderMoni, MarketMoni, FarmerMoni)
GRM	Grievance Redress Mechanism
GVG	Grants for Vulnerable Groups
HGSF / NHGSFP	(National) Home-Grown School Feeding Programme, sister NSIP programme; subject of Brief 3
HoPE-CT	Home-Grown Poverty Eradication Cash Transfer, transfer stream under the Renewed Hope reset
ICPC	Independent Corrupt Practices and Other Related Offences Commission
IDA	International Development Association (World Bank concessional credit window)
IEG	Independent Evaluation Group (World Bank)
ILO	International Labour Organization
IPA / J-PAL	Innovations for Poverty Action / Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab, randomized-evaluation research bodies
LGA	Local Government Area (Nigeria has 774)
MERL	Monitoring, Evaluation, Research and Learning
MIS	Management Information System

NASSCO	National Social Safety Nets Coordinating Office
NBS	National Bureau of Statistics
NCTO	National Cash Transfer Office
NDE	National Directorate of Employment
NEET	Not in Employment, Education or Training
NEIP	National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme (Ghana comparator)
NEXIT	N-Power's exit/transition portal for exiting batches (stalled)
NIMC	National Identity Management Commission
NSIO	National Social Investment Office, original coordinating office, predecessor to NSIPA
NSIP	National Social Investment Programme, umbrella suite of N-Power, HGSF, CCT, GEEP
NSIPA	National Social Investment Programme Agency, statutory agency (2023 Act) now administering NSIP
NSR	National Social Registry
NYSC	National Youth Service Corps
OAGF	Office of the Accountant-General of the Federation
ODA	Official Development Assistance
PAD	Project Appraisal Document (World Bank)
PIRS	Performance Indicator Reference Sheet
PSG	Priority Skills for Growth (Rwanda comparator programme)
RCT	Randomized Controlled Trial
RHJCP	Renewed Hope Job Creation Programme, N-Power's renamed form from October 2023
SMEDAN	Small and Medium Enterprises Development Agency of Nigeria
SSN	Social Safety Net
SURE-P GIS	Subsidy Reinvestment and Empowerment Programme, Graduate Internship Scheme, N-Power's direct 2012-2015 predecessor
ToC	Theory of Change
Tracer study	Post-exit longitudinal survey of ex-beneficiaries at defined intervals (standard: 6/12/24 months)
TSA	Treasury Single Account
VAIDS	Voluntary Assets and Income Declaration Scheme, referenced within the N-Tax sub-scheme
YESSO	Youth Employment and Social Support Operation (World Bank-financed state-level programme)

ANNEX D: STANDARDS COMPLIANCE MAP

This annex audits the unified draft against the MERL writing standards (the companion practice guide, *writing for MERL*), so a reviewer can verify the document defends itself against the framework it was commissioned under.

Standard requirement (MERL writing standards)	**Where this draft complies**	**Notes**
Clear, answerable question; grounded in prior knowledge	Sections 1-2 establish the object and prior programme knowledge; Sections 3-4 pose and bound the answerable questions	Section 2.4 names the question the review can raise but not close, and says why
Appropriate methodology; match between methods and questions	Methodological Note: secondary synthesis design chosen because primary records are inaccessible; limitations registered instead of concealed	No primary data collection claimed or implied
Empirical evidence; claims traceable to data	In-text author-year tagging throughout; Annex A reproduces the matrix; derived figures flagged at point of use	Self-auditing chain: claim → author-year citation → Annex A → public source
Five sentence types separated (facts / findings / conclusions / recommendations / opinions)	Section subheadings and "(conclusion, flagged)" / "assessment" labels separate judgments from evidence; testimony is quoted and attributed; recommendations confined to Section 8 with evidence links	Writer's judgments appear openly as judgments
Validity/reliability caution; no causal overreach	Contribution-not-attribution language throughout; the employment verdict explicitly a verdict on absence of measurement (§7.2); trustworthiness addressed via triangulation across 8 source categories	No fabricated rates; no averaging-away of contradictions (Table 6)
Honest quantification: denominators, direction,	Denominators stated with every percentage; bands replace false points (₦3,000-₦5,000; 9-18%);	Denominator sensitivity on ghost share stated in text, not

precision discipline, disaggregation	disaggregation used where available (Lagos sample), its absence reported as a finding (§3.4)	buried
Limitations specific and consequential	Section 7 subsections each state what the limitation lets findings bear; Annex E registers open actions	Limitations appear in-text where they bite (deflator caveat in §4.5), not only at the end
Ethics, equity, non-stigmatizing language	People-first descriptors; testimony protection called for in R9 (non-retaliation, cell suppression); equity analysis in §3.4 with gender figures and geographic need	No vulnerable respondent is identified; curated social-media material treated with declared bias controls
Terminology governance: one term, one meaning; glossary; acronyms expanded once	Author-year referencing standardized; "Renewed Hope framing" used consistently; Annex C glossary expands all acronyms	Legacy acronym families (M&E/MEL/MEAL/MERL) not mixed into this review's object vocabulary
Results-chain discipline (outputs vs outcomes vs impact)	§5.2 and Table 5/Annex B measure by ToC link; the review's core criticism of N-Power is itself expressed in results-chain terms	The review practices the measurement discipline it demands
Findings → conclusions → recommendations traceability	Section 8 recommendations each carry an evidence-link column (Table 7); each cites the section and sources it rests on	FCR chain auditable end-to-end
Recommendations: actor + action + instrument + timeframe	R1-R10 and P1-P2 each name a responsible institution and a named instrument; R1 actor corrected to National Assembly	Where the actor is legislative, it is assigned to the legislature, not the agency
Thoroughness over length; completeness tests	Every evaluation question posed is answered or registered as unanswerable-with-reason; no section ends on unflagged uncertainty	Gaps shown as gaps (Charts 1-2 data tables) rather than interpolated
Version integrity and reconciliation	Methodological Note; short reconciliation note; Annex E; this Annex	A reviewer can see exactly what changed between source drafts and why

Residual non-compliances (declared): (i) the FOIA filing (E1) remains outstanding, so primary-record verification remains unavailable; (ii) the composite nature of some matrix rows, for example the SURE-P precursor row (Premium Times, 2013, bundling academic sources) and the civil-society row (FIJ, 2024; ANEEJ, 2025), means some claims trace to a bundle rather than a single document, resolvable in the repository's full matrix.

ANNEX E: OUTSTANDING DATA ACTIONS AND EXTRACTION REGISTER

Registered actions required to complete the evidence base and render the three charts. Each names the gap, the action, the affected section/chart, and the owning matrix row.

#	Outstanding item	Action required	Affects	Matrix row
E1	Formal FOIA filing to NSIPA	File formal FOIA request (batch/state/LGA counts; results framework; 2024 panel findings; ₦30bn custody; any tracer); log reference number and date as author-side record	§5.1, §7.5; Charts 1-2	–
E2	N-Power-specific release/utilization series, 2016-2024	Extract from BudgIT year-editions + OAGF/Budget Office cross-check; do not substitute ministry envelopes without labelling	Chart 1	S7
E3	2026 graduate-population denominator; NDE/ITF comparator detail	Extract successor NBS labour-force series on revised methodology; extract NDE/ITF scale, reach and outcome documentation	§4.2, §4.3	S13, S16
E4	2016 base-month food-price level (re-based series); full annual Food CPI 2016-2026	Extract from NBS CPI archive into chart CSV; plot re-base break visibly	Chart 3	S15
E5	NSIPA Establishment Act full text	Confirm full Act PDF at nass.gov.ng; verify statutory M&E mandate wording and operationalization status	§6.3, R1	S27
E6	YouWiN! full citation	Pin full AER citation (McKenzie) and URL for the 7,027-jobs result	§1.3, §4.3, §5.4, R2	S30
E7	Five-million-target primary post	Locate and archive the specific ministry post stating the 5M target (currently cited at institutional level only)	§2.3, §6.4	S5
E8	Mechanism-isolation study	Commission/design study isolating cash vs. deployment as the active ingredient (registered research gap from §4.1)	§4.1	S12, S18
E9	Uwais interview timestamps	Pin precise timestamps for the Sun TV interview to upgrade citation precision	§1.2	S26
E10	Digital/private-platform alternatives data	Locate reach/outcome data for jobs boards, gig and micro-work platforms for Nigerian graduates	§4.3	S16